

Agreement variation and optionality in Spanish existential clauses

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Abstract: This paper offers a novel framework for understanding agreement variation and optionality in Spanish existential clauses involving the verb *haber*. In these existential sentences, though the prescriptive norm is for verbal agreement to always surface as third person singular, a significant number of speakers allow for conditional agreement with the postverbal DP associate/pivot (Rodríguez Mondoñedo 2006). I show that, for these speakers, verbal agreement may optionally occur with a third person plural associate, and is obligatory with a first or second person plural associate. These agreement relations are established via a mechanism known as defective circumvention (Storment 2025), in which a phi-probe may conditionally search past a goal that it has already agreed with and go on to agree with a second goal, given that the first goal does not bear all of the features that the probe is specified to search for. Additionally, using data from nonstandard Spanish varieties, I explain some morphosyntactic irregularities of the existential verb *haber* and how they follow the analysis of existential clauses given in the paper. Finally, this paper offers a new way of thinking about agreement optionality and intraspeaker variation in which multiple valid outputs are derived within a single grammar.

Keywords: existentials, Spanish syntax, agreement optionality, defective circumvention, intraspeaker variation, locative clitic

1 Introduction

Spanish is known to show agreement variation in existential clauses containing the existential verb *haber*, which has historically (among other things) meant ‘to have’. In this way, Spanish can be classified into two dialects (e.g., Rodríguez Mondoñedo 2006): one in which verbal agreement always surfaces as third person singular (1a), and one in which verbal agreement may match the phi-features of the clausal “associate” (the DP whose existence is being asserted, also called the “pivot”) (1b).

- (1) a. **Hubo** dos hombres en la fiesta (Rodríguez Mondoñedo 2006:326-27)
 had.3sg two men in the party
 ‘There **was** two men at the party’
 b. **Hubieron** dos hombres en la fiesta
 had.3pl two men in the party
 ‘There **were** two men at the party’

In the non-agreeing dialect (1a), the lack of verbal agreement is obligatory. In the agreeing dialect (1b), however, verbal agreement with a third person plural associate is optional. In other words, speakers who accept (1b) also accept (1a), though not every speaker who accepts (1a) accepts (1b). This assertion directly contradicts Rodríguez Mondoñedo (2006: fn. 19), and I discuss it further on. Thus, the two dialects – SI for the non-agreeing dialect and SII for the agreeing dialect as Rodríguez-Mondoñedo (2006) refers to them – are more accurately characterized as follows, with SI indicated in (2a) and SII indicated in (2b).

- (2) a. **Hubo** dos hombres en la fiesta (SI)
 had.3sg two men in the party
 ‘There **was** two men at the party’

- b. {**Hubieron/hubo**} dos hombres en la fiesta (SII)
 {**had.3pl/ had.3sg**} two men in the party
 ‘There {**were/was**} two men at the party’

Furthermore, in the dialect SII which optionally allows agreement with a third person plural associate, verbal agreement can track a first or second person plural associate which necessarily refers to the speaker or addressee. This agreement does not seem obligatory.

- (3) a. **Habemos** dos estudiantes en la clase (Rodríguez-Mondoñedo 2006:355)
 have.1pl two students in the class
 ‘There are two of us students in the class’
 b. **Habéis** dos estudiantes en la clase
 have.2pl two students in the class
 ‘There are two of y’all students in the class’

Using the framework of sequential, conditional Multiple Agree known as *defective circumvention* (Storment 2025) in which a phi-probe may conditionally probe and Agree past a phi-deficient goal and enter into another Agree relation with a lower, featurally non-deficient goal, I show how both possibilities for agreement shown in (2b) are possible in dialects of Spanish (SII) which allow for associate agreement. I further demonstrate how obligatory agreement with a first or second person (or [Part]-bearing) associate DP is possible in these varieties of Spanish. This paper is mainly about SII, though I discuss SI at some points.

Additionally, I discuss outstanding issues concerning the definiteness effect in these existential clauses (Milsark 1977; 1979; Safir 1982; 1987; Szabolcsi 1986a; b; Heim 1987; Diesing 1992; Abbott 1993; Rigau 1993; 1997; Moro 1997; Keenan 2003; Sheehan 2016; Fischer & Kupsich 2016; Kayne 2016a; 2018, Agulló 2023; a.o), as well as some morphological irregularities with the existential verb *haber* and the fact that accusative Case is assigned to the associate DP (Saab 2006). I also offer an explanation as to why speakers whose grammars allow for optionality may display preferences for certain forms over others. These discussions and analyses are crucially informed by data from nonstandard and colloquial varieties of Spanish, the insights from which inform this analysis in crucial ways and cause us to arrive at conclusions that would otherwise be overlooked if they were not considered.

This paper is structured as follows. In section 2, I give the underlying structure of Spanish existential clauses and explain their characteristic agreement optionality seen in SII, and how they can be explained under a unified system of Agree. In Section 3, I explore the effects that a [Part]-bearing associate has on the agreement in these types of clauses. In Section 4, I discuss some morphological quirks of the existential verb *haber* and how they naturally fall out from the structure and analysis of clausal agreement that I have presented in the prior sections. Section 5 concludes, and there I discuss some outstanding questions and connections to other cases of agreement optionality and variation.

2 Agreement optionality with *haber*

In some varieties of Spanish (SI), agreement with existential *haber* always surfaces as third person singular, regardless of the verb tense or of features of the associate DP. Indeed, this pattern is the prescriptive norm as well (RAE 2025). It is shown in (4).

- (4) a. Ha -y un problema (SI)
has-LOC a problem
'There is a problem'
b. {Había/ *había-n} varios problemas
{had.3sg/*had -3pl} various problems
'There {is/*are} various problems'
c. {Hubo/ *hubieron} varios problemas
{had.3sg/*had.3pl} various problems
'There {was/*were} various problems'
d. {Habrà/ *habrà -n} varios problemas
{have.FUT.3sg/*have.FUT-3pl} various problems
'There will be various problems'

The third person present tense singular form includes the locative clitic -y, which I discuss further in section 4. It is sufficient for now to say of the non-agreeing dialect (SI) that the mechanism I go on to describe for agreement optionality with third person plural associates in SII is not available in SI.

In SII, singular and plural agreement are both possible with a postverbal third person plural subject.

- (5) a. Ha -y un problema (SII)
has-LOC a problem
'There is a problem'
b. {Había-n/ había} varios problemas
{had -3pl/had.3sg} various problems
'There {are/is} various problems'
c. {Hubieron/hubo} varios problemas
{had.3pl/ had.3sg} various problems
'There {were/was} various problems'
d. {Habrà -n/ habrá} varios problemas
{have.FUT-3pl/have.FUT.3sg} various problems
'There will be various problems'

Though Rodríguez Mondoñedo (2006) rejects the idea of optional agreement for speakers of SII, this idea is defended elsewhere (Kany 1967; Contreras 1976; Westphal 1978; De Mello 1991; Treviño 2003). This work also considers the patterns of agreement in SII to be optional. I explicitly defend this position in section 2.4, which I assume in the following analysis.

2.1 Arguments of existential *haber*

Despite any common misconceptions that may exist, the associate of the existential verb *haber* (i.e., the postverbal DP) is not a postverbal subject. The most compelling evidence of this is that, in many varieties of Spanish, the associate can appear as an object clitic.

- (6) a. Ha -y un hombre en la habitación (Rodríguez Mondoñedo 2006:326)
has-LOC a man in the room
'There is a man in the room'
b. Lo ha -y
CL.ACC has-LOC
'There is him'

The ability to appear as an object clitic is evidence that the associate DP is not a structural subject and bears accusative Case (Saab 2006).

Further evidence that the associate is not the structural subject comes from the fact that wh-extraction out of an *haber* associate DP is possible (Díaz 2004; Rodríguez Mondoñedo 2006).

- (7) a. Ha -y libros de sintaxis en mi cuarto (Díaz 2004:70)
has-LOC books of syntax in my room
'There are books about syntax in my room'
b. ¿De qué ha -y libros en mi cuarto?
of what has-LOC books in my room
'About what are there books in my room?'

We can compare this to a sentence with a similar meaning (indeed, two clause types that are often compared) in which the same DP is the structural subject.

- (8) a. Los libros de sintaxis están en mi cuarto (Díaz 2004:71)
the books of syntax are in my room
'The syntax books are in my room'
b. *¿De qué están los libros en mi cuarto?
of what are the books in my room
int: 'About what are the books in my room?'

Changing the status of the subject DP in (8) to a postverbal subject does nothing to improve the grammaticality of (8b), either, which shows that it cannot be the case that the associate of *haber* is a postverbal subject.

- (9) a. En mi cuarto están los libros de sintaxis
in my room are the books of syntax
'In my room are the books about syntax'
b. *¿De qué están en mi cuarto los libros?
of what are in my room the books
int: 'About what are in my room the books?'

It is well known that *wh*-movement out of a structural subject DP is not possible, while such extraction from an object position is possible (Ross 1967; Huang 1982; Rizzi 1990; Stepanov 2007; a.o). Thus, it cannot be the case that the associate DP of existential *haber* sentences is a subject.

Further diagnostics for the objecthood of the associate DP here are presented in Rodríguez Mondoñedo (2006), and he additionally shows that, when the associate does appear preverbally, it is due to some $\bar{A}$ -movement such as focus.

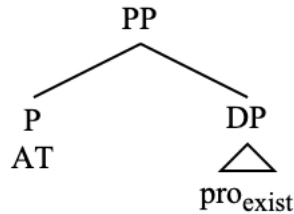
Given that the associate DP of *haber* clauses is not the structural subject, and given that Spanish does have a requirement for a structural subject in Spec,TP (Suñer 1982; 2000; 2003; Pinto 1994; Adger 1996; Zubizarreta 1998; Goodall 2001; Kučerová 2014; a.o), there is a pressing question of what actually does serve as the structural subject in existential *haber* clauses.

Aside from the structural requirement to have another subject, we know that there is one because it can be agreed with: obligatorily in SI, and optionally in SII.

This structural subject is an existential argument: an element like Italian *ci* or English ‘there’ which functions as the structural subject of existential clauses (Moro 1997; Tortora 2014; Storment 2025). This argument in most varieties of Spanish is null.

This existential argument is selected by existential *haber*, and as such is not a true expletive as it is lexically selected (Larson 1989:20). It has existential semantics (Freeze 1992), meaning that it denotes a contextually specified universe in which the existence of the associate DP is being asserted. Following Storment (2025), I assume that the existential argument is underlyingly a PP. I give its structure below.

(10) Structure of the existential argument in Spanish



The elements making up this argument have the following semantic denotations.

- (11)
- a. $\llbracket \text{pro}_{\text{exist}} \rrbracket = \mathcal{U}$
 - b. $\llbracket \text{AT} \rrbracket = \lambda P \lambda x. x \in P$
 - c. $\llbracket \text{AT } \text{pro}_{\text{exist}} \rrbracket = \lambda x. x \in \mathcal{U}$

According to these semantics, an existential sentence such as (12)a with the invisible structure in (12)b has the same truth value as the gloss in (12)c.

- (12) a. Ha -y un hombre
has-LOC a man
‘There is a man’
b. [AT pro_{exist}] ha -y un hombre
[AT pro_{exist}] has-LOC a man
‘There is a man’
c. In the (contextually restricted) universe exists a man

This existential argument can be further coindexed with referential deictic PPs (Hale & Keyser 2002; Storment 2025), so that a sentence such as *Hay un hombre en el jardín* has the truth value of ‘In the garden there exists a man’.

This existential argument being underlyingly a PP is corroborated by the fact that, in some varieties of Caribbean Spanish, the existential argument is overt, and has the form *ello* (Toribio 2000; Martínez-Sanz 2011; Muñoz Pérez 2014).

- (13) **Ello** tiene que haber otro paso (Martínez-Sanz 2011:30)
it has that have.INF other path
‘There has to be another path’

Although the historical use of *ello* was less restricted (Uriagereka 1995; Silva Villar 1998; Muñoz Pérez 2014), in contemporary Spanish it is restricted to these dialectal instances of serving as an existential or Ambient subject, or as the object of a preposition (in all Spanishes).

- (14) Ahora vamos por todo y todos vamos **por ello**
now go.1pl for all and all go.1pl **for it**
‘Now we’re going for it all and we’re all going for it’

The fact that this subject survives as *ello* when *ello* is otherwise restricted to a PP-object position is evidence that this subject is underlyingly a PP headed by a null preposition, which is consistent with the structure of the existential argument presented in (10).

The treatment of existential arguments as PPs further explains their phi-deficiency: namely, that they lack a number feature (Chomsky 1981; 2001; Béjar 2003:62; Deal 2009; Tsiakmakis & Espinal 2022; Storment 2025). Other nominals that underlyingly involve PPs and are number-deficient include dative nominals, which are analyzed as being contained within a PP “shell” (Rezac 2004; 2008; Bjorkman & Zeijlstra 2019; Fernández-Serrano 2022), and some locative light noun configurations (Kishimoto 2000; Collins 2007).

Further evidence that PPs lack a number feature comes from the fact that locative PPs cannot be pluralized.

- (15) a. *Todos mis hermanos están aquí-s
 all my brothers are here-PL
 int: ‘All my brothers are heres’
 b. *Por allí -s están los bares
 for there-PL are the bars
 int: ‘Over theres are the bars’

Nor can PPs which are semantically plural ever trigger any kind of plural agreement¹.

- (16) *En todos los jardines están la flor más hermosa
 in all the gardens are the flower most beautiful
 int: ‘In all the gardens are the most beautiful flower’

Further motivation to claim that this existential argument is a PP is the fact that there is a locative clitic *-y* with this subject when it appears as the subject of the third person singular present tense verb. This clitic has a wider distribution in related languages such as French *y* (Henry 1974; Kayne 2004; 2010), Italian *ci* (Moro 1997; Tortora 2014), and Catalan *hi* (Fabra 1956; Bonet 1991; Rigau 1982), but in Spanish only remains in this one environment.

I present an analysis in which this locative clitic appears via agreement with a [Loc] feature on the subject, which comes about from the subject’s status as a PP (i.e., a locative element). As I show further on, the presence of this locative feature is crucial in capturing the word order and morphological idiosyncrasies of this construction and its verb.

Given the discussion above on the status of the subject and object arguments of the existential verb *haber* and their semantics, as well as considerations on the argument structure of existential and locative verbs (Larson 1989; Moro 1997; Hale & Keyser 2002; Tortora 2014; Storment 2025), I give the following structure as the positions in which the arguments of *haber* are externally merged.

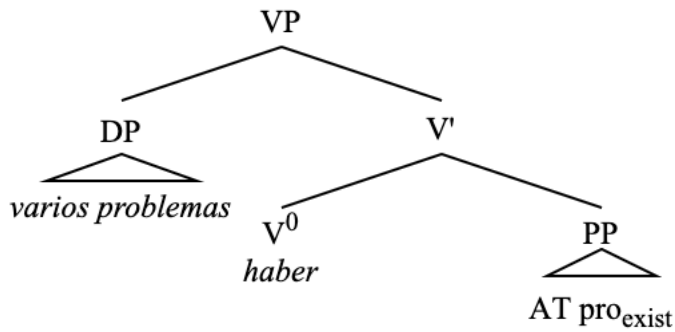
- (17) a. Ha-y varios problemas
 has-LOC various problems
 ‘There is various problems’

¹ Some locatives inside of coordinate structures may occasionally trigger plural agreement.

- (i) Aquí y allí me gustan (Goodall 2001:207)
 here and there me please-3pl
 ‘I like here and there’

Outside of these limited cases, however, it still stands that PPs may not trigger plural agreement or appear with plural morphology (indeed, the locatives in (i) still do not appear with any plural morphology). Thus, it stands to reason that the plural agreement in (i) is a result of the coordinate structure more than it is the result of any PP bearing a number feature.

b. Argument structure of (17a)



With this structure in mind, it is now possible to sketch how the agreement optionality seen in SII varieties of Spanish can be derived within a single system of Agree.

2.2 Defective probing and agreement optionality

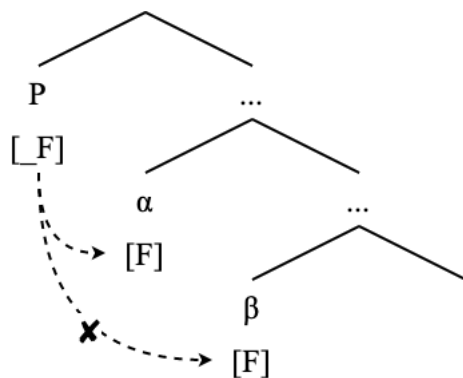
I adopt here a maximally simple formulation of Agree that effectively reduces to Minimal Search (Chomsky 2000; 2001).

(18) *Strong Minimalist formulation of Agree* (Chomsky 2000; 2001; 2004)

- (i) **Search – Minimal Search: Locality reduces to closest c-command in D(P)**
- (ii) Match – Matching is feature identity
- (iii) Copy – Copy features from Goal (G) to Probe (P)

As such, we need only make reference to a probe's featural specification and that it searches for and finds the closest (defined in terms of asymmetrical c-command (Chomsky 1995; Ura 2000)) corresponding instance of that feature.

(19) Agree as Minimal Search

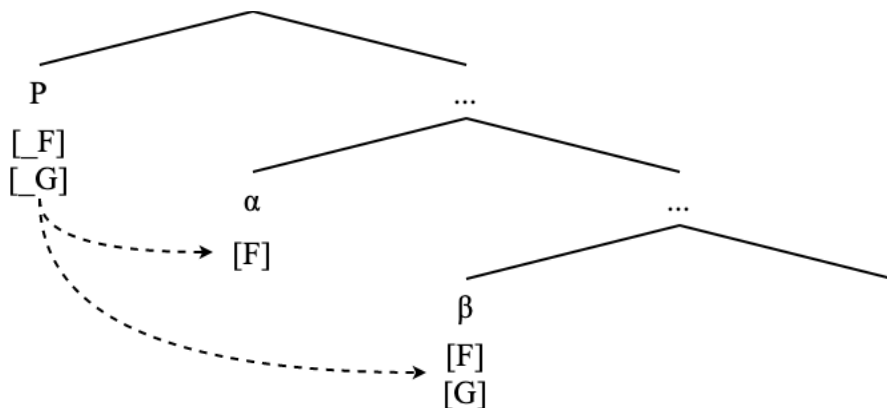


This is how clausal verbal agreement normally works in Spanish. A phi-probe on T⁰ searches for the closest goal bearing the relevant set of phi-features that the probe is specified to find. The goal is most often the structural subject of the clause, which most often bears all of the corresponding phi-features that the probe is searching for, and there that usually the only

argument that is sufficiently local to the probe. Hence, verbal agreement most often tracks exclusively the structural subject.

Although, if the structural subject is phi-deficient with respect to the relevant probe (meaning that it bears a nonzero proper subset of the features on the probe), and if there is another nondeficient goal in the search space of the probe, then a probe may end up undergoing Agree with more than one goal.

(20) Minimal Search with a phi-deficient goal

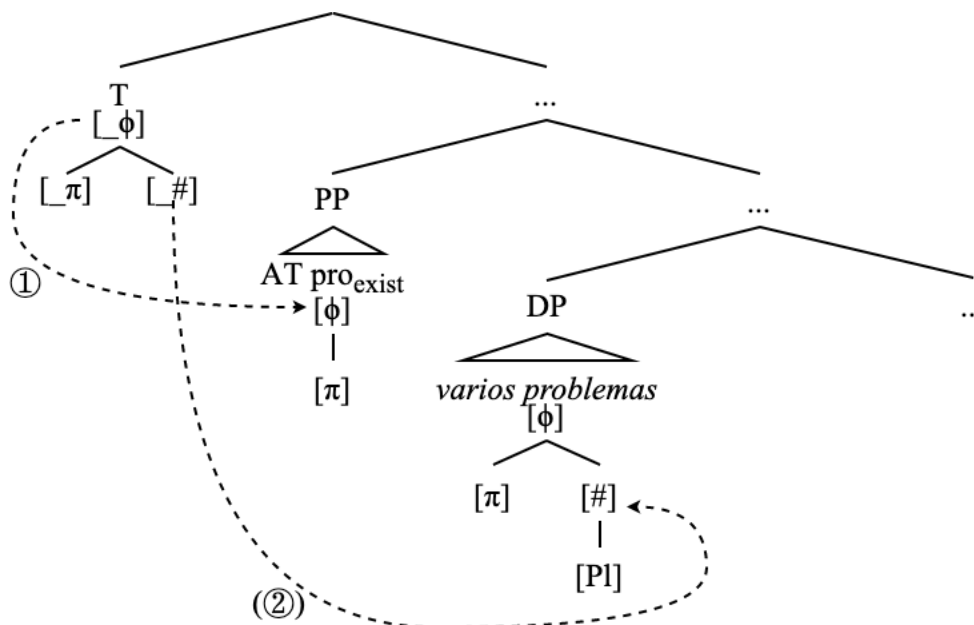


The probing past α to Agree with β here is known as *defective circumvention*, a conditional process by which probe P enters into an Agree relation with a higher phi-deficient goal α and then conditionally goes on to Agree past α with a lower, more featurally-specified goal β (Storment 2025). This conditional sequential probing is responsible for the agreement optionality seen with existential *haber* sentences with third person plural associates in SII.

In these structures, I adopt the hierarchical syntactic representation of phi-features known as feature geometries (Harley & Ritter 2002). I assume that feature geometries are present on phi-probes as well as phi-goals (Béjar 2003; Preminger 2014, and I assume that feature copying is coarse in that a search for any given feature in a geometry will result in the copying of the entire feature-geometric structure containing feature from the goal to the probe (Béjar 2003; Preminger 2014; Coon & Keine 2021). I further assume that the root node of a feature geometry obligatorily initiates Search (Béjar 2003; Preminger 2014; Storment 2025), and that non-root nodes may or may not obligatorily trigger a Search depending on the requirements of the specific feature occupying the node, which I expound upon further on. Given these considerations, we can see how defective circumvention leads to agreement optionality in Spanish existential clauses.

- (21) a. {Hubo/ hubieron} varios problemas
 {had.3sg/had.3pl} various problems
 ‘There {was/were} various problems’

b. Agreement probe and goals in (21a)



In this derivation, the phi-probe on T^0 initiates a search for any goal bearing the relevant feature $[\phi]$. The probe $[\phi]$ obligatorily searches first, since it is the root node of the feature geometry. The closest goal bearing $[\phi]$ is the existential argument PP $[AT \text{ pro}_{\text{exist}}]$ ².

The PP goal is phi-deficient – it lacks number $[\#]$ but bears person $[\pi]$ ³. As a result, when the features of the PP are copied back to the probe, all the features of the probe are “valued” (in the sense of Preminger (2014)) except for number. As the first element that the probe agrees with, the existential PP moves to the structural subject position and receives nominative Case (Chomsky 2000; 2001; Miyagawa 2010). This Agree relation is schematized as ① in (21b).

At this point, the phi-probe is valued for $[\phi]$ and $[\pi]$, but it has not been valued for number, as it has only undergone Agree with a phi-goal that lacks number. With the phi-probe being valued in this way, the syntax has two choices: it can either stop probing and spell out third person singular agreement on the verb (i.e., *hubo* ‘there was’), or it can probe again for number, in which case it would find the plural feature on the associate DP and then spell out third person plural agreement

² It must be the case that PPs have some phi-feature specification as they are visible to phi-probes. We know that they are valid phi-goals as they can be agreed with (see example (i) as well as Storment (2025: ch. 3)) and can undergo A-movement (Murphy 2022). Additionally, PPs serve as phase edges (Citko 2014). If the observation that all phasehood can be reduced to relativized minimality in phi-probing (Halpert & Zeijlstra 2024) is on the right track, then PPs should be specified at least partially for phi-features. In other words, PPs are interveners for phi-probing (van Riemsdijk 1978; Chomsky 2000; Hiraiwa 2001), which could only happen if they themselves bear phi-features. Given that PPs lack a number specification (see fn. 1), it must be the case that they bear only a person feature: specifically third person, as they cannot refer to a speech act participant (Harley & Ritter 2002; Storment 2025).

³ Indeed, phi-deficient DPs are typologically uniform in this way. $[\pi]$ is attested in the absence of $[\#]$, but not vice-versa. In other words, a search for $[\phi]$ will never value $[\#]$ to the exclusion of $[\pi]$. Probing of $[\phi]$ necessarily bleeds probing of $[\pi]$, but not of $[\#]$, because an element with $[\phi]$ will necessarily also contain $[\pi]$, but not necessarily $[\#]$ (Harley & Ritter 2002; Storment 2025).

on the verb (i.e., *hubieron* ‘there were’). This second option is what is known as defective circumvention. It is optional, and is schematized in (21b) with (2). Defective circumvention is defined as follows.

- (22) *Defective Circumvention* (Storment 2025)
 A probe P enters into an Agree relation with a higher phi-deficient goal α and then conditionally goes on to Agree past α with a lower, more featurally-specified goal β .
 a. Agree without defective circumvention → 3sg “default” agreement (*hubo*)
 b. Agree with defective circumvention → agreement with associate (*hubieron*)

If defective circumvention does occur, it is because the number feature on the phi-probe initiates a search for the closest goal bearing [#], which in (21b) is the associate DP *varios problemas* ‘various problems’. The entire feature geometry is then copied back to the phi-probe, and, since there is no feature conflict between the two goals that the probe has now undergone Agree with (e.g., there is no [Non-Participant] feature on the PP to conflict with a [Participant] feature on the associate DP) the probe matches the featural makeup of the associate DP (as well as the PP, whose phi-featural makeup is a proper subset of the phi-features of the associate). This causes verbal agreement to be spelled out with the plural feature of the associate, leading to *hubieron* ‘there were’.

As such, the optionality between *hubo* ‘there was’ and *hubieron* ‘there were’ in (21) is a result of whether or not a second probing cycle for [#] – schematized as (2) – takes place. It is not immediately obvious how something like this could be optional, especially in a system of Agree such as those presented in Preminger (2014) or Deal (2024) where every probing feature must initiate a search (regardless of whether or not that search is successful). In the system of Agree presented in Storment (2025) and adopted here that allows for defective circumvention, however, the only obligatory search is one that is initiated by the root node of a feature-geometric structure, as well as those features which carry a discourse-related requirement to participate in an Agree relation (see the Person Licensing Condition (Béjar & Rezac 2003)), which I return to in the following section. Given that [_#] is neither a root node of a feature geometry on the probe in (21b), nor does it carry a special requirement on its own to participate in an Agree relation, whether or not it initiates a search is optional.

How the optionality itself works out in the grammar is worthy of some discussion, since pure optionality in any area of a grammar is notable. I frame the optionality here as a violation of a kind of preference that results from general economy conditions in the grammar (Chomsky 2001; Chomsky 2024). By this I mean: probes initiating searches is costly in the syntax, as is having to assign an interpretive value to any features on a probe that remain unvalued.

For a probe to have to initiate multiple searches, as in the case of defective circumvention ((2)) obtaining, is therefore doubly costly, and violates a preference in the grammar to not probe more times than is necessary, which falls out from general principles of economy.

Additionally, having leftover unvalued features is costly as well, as it requires some additional work in the grammar to assign an interpretive value to the unvalued feature on the probe at the interfaces, for instance Partial Default Agreement (PDA) from Béjar (2003) and similar

proposals elsewhere (e.g., Fernández Serrano 2022). Having a mechanism such as PDA kick in is an additional operation to be performed that would not be necessary if the probe were to find the relevant feature. As such, we can speak of this in terms of a preference in the grammar to not have to resort to something like PDA unless absolutely necessary, or for a probe to attempt to value all of its features, which once again falls out from general economy principles.

In this framework, the option to not probe again for number in (21) (leading to singular verbal agreement) is costly – and therefore dispreferred – in terms of economy, as it requires some additional interpretive mechanism such as PDA. The option to probe again for number (leading to plural verbal agreement) is also dispreferred under economy, though, as it requires a second cycle of probing.

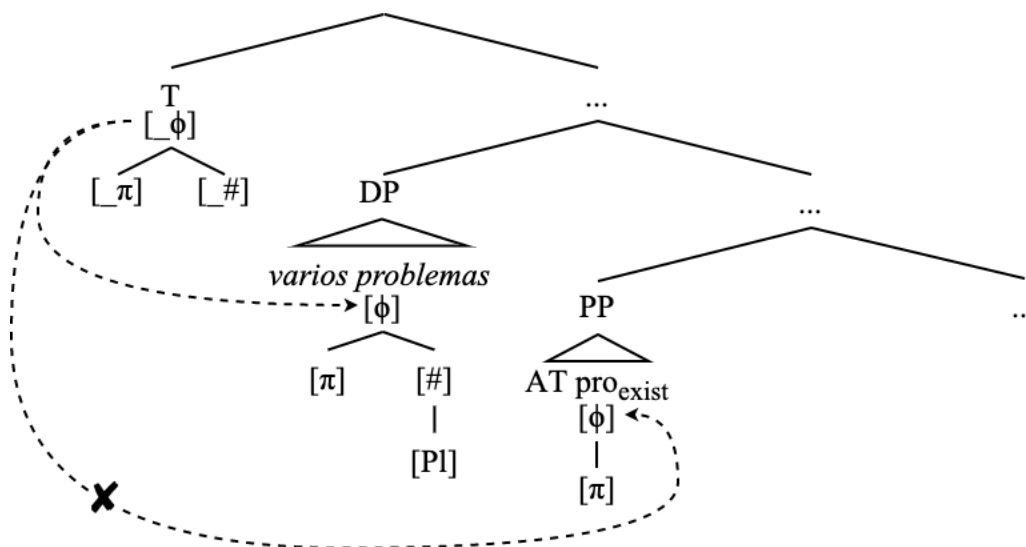
If one of these outcomes were more economical than the other, then we would not expect optionality, as the grammar would tend to go the more economical route; however, given that both choices represent some kind of violation of economy preferences, we end up with two valid spellout choices in the same derivation, driven by the optionality of probing again for number⁴.

2.3 A locative probe on v^0

As the reader may have noticed, the existential argument PP crucially must appear in a position above the associate DP in (21) in order for defective circumvention to be a valid option, and indeed for agreement with the existential PP to be a valid option at all. If the associate DP were to asymmetrically c-command the existential PP at the time of phi-probing by T^0 , then the existential PP would never be visible to the phi-probe as all the probe's features would be valued by the associate DP. See the following.

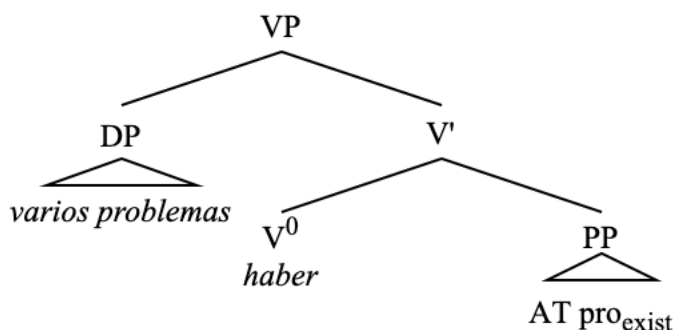
⁴ We can further imagine some kind of grammatical preference marking system (Prince & Smolensky 1993; McCarthy & Prince 1995) in which one of these economy preference violations is marked as more “fatal” than the other, in which case we would end up with a system in which only one outcome is preferred over the other. This could mean a scenario in which probing more than once is more “fatal”, thus leading to a grammar that only allows third person singular verbal agreement (e.g., SI), and could also allow for a system in which PDA is more “fatal” than multiple probing, thus leading to a grammar in which third person singular verbal agreement is not possible (or strongly dispreferred) in existential clauses.

(23) Positions of arguments being reversed at time of probing $\Rightarrow$ invisibility of existential PP



As the reader may have also noticed, the necessary ordering of the arguments [existential PP] > [associate DP] was not the order of the base positions of these arguments in (17), repeated here.

- (24) a. Ha-y varios problemas
 has-LOC various problems
 ‘There is various problems’
 b. Argument structure of (17a)



In its base position, the associate DP asymmetrically c-commands the existential argument PP, which is crucially not the order that these arguments should be in at the time of probing by T^0 . Without assuming any notions of equidistance – which presents significant complications to any uniform theory of minimality (Stormont 2025:18) and which does not rule out the possibility of the promotion of the associate DP to the position of structural subject (which it cannot be) – there must be a way for the existential argument PP to undergo A-movement to a position above the associate DP before T^0 is externally merged.

As such, there is more to the story of the clausal structure of these existential constructions (hence why I was agnostic about the exact position of these arguments in (21)). It is now

necessary to discuss the presence and featural makeup of the *vP* projection⁵ in Spanish existential clauses.

Following Rodríguez Mondoñedo (2006), I assume that Spanish existential *haber* clauses have a *vP* projected. I also assume that the head of this *vP* has an agreement probe necessary to compute the patterns of agreement and the morphological idiosyncrasies of this construction. I do not, however, assume that the feature that *v*⁰ probes for is number (Rodríguez Mondoñedo 2006:326). Rather, I propose that the *v*⁰ projected by the existential verb *haber* contains a probe for a locative feature [_{LOC}]⁶. This locative *vP* is unique to the existential verb and explains the presence of the locative agreement clitic *-y* with present tense existential *haber* as well as the fact that the existential argument PP serves as the structural subject of the clause.

It should not be the case that the existential argument is itself externally merged in Spec,*vP* (e.g., Deal 2009, though this would get the ordering of the arguments right for probing by *T*⁰. If we take seriously the implications of configurational theta theory (Gruber 1997; Hale & Keyser 2002), UTAH (Baker 1988; 1997), and the Theta-Criterion (Chomsky 1987; Collins 2024), then an existential argument, which is locative in nature (Freeze 1992; Tortora 2014; a.o), should not be externally merged in an external argument agent position.

Additionally, the existential argument PP needs to move *through* Spec,*vP* via Agree in order for the locative agreement clitic *-y* to surface where it does (namely, below *T*⁰), which is crucial for capturing the various morphological idiosyncrasies of the existential verb, which I return to in section 4.

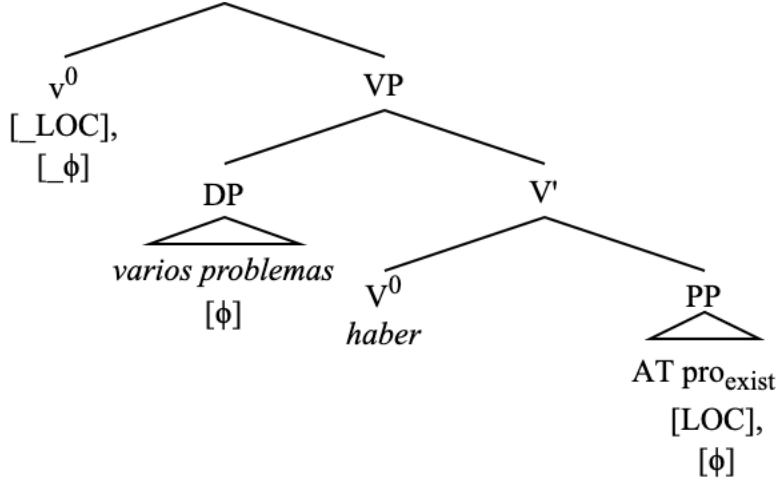
The projection *vP* is also necessary in this derivation to license the structural object, which is the associate. Assuming a functional-head-and-Agree-based theory of Case assignment (Chomsky 2000; 2001), *vP* is necessary to assign accusative Case to a structural object (Burzio 1986). Without this projection, even though it does not introduce an external argument, the derivation of existential *haber* clauses would not be possible as accusative Case could not be assigned to the associate DP.

The derivation of this structure is as follows. A *v*⁰ head is merged with a [_{LOC}] probe feature and a [_ϕ] probe feature, and takes VP as its complement.

⁵ I do not mean *vP* in the sense of a verbalizing head, as is presently common in many treatments of the verbal projection domain (see D'Alessandro et. al 2017, Part I). Rather, I mean *vP* as an applicative head that may introduce an external argument and plays a role in the licensing and Case assignment of arguments introduced in the c-command domain of *v*⁰, a projection that is often referred to as VoiceP (see again D'Alessandro et. al, Part II). I do not adopt the VoiceP conception of *vP* as there are numerous conceptual and empirical reasons to separate the head responsible from grammatical voice phenomena from the head involved in introducing an external argument and licensing the internal arguments of a verb (Merchant 2013; Myler & Mali 2023; Collins 2024; Storment 2025; a.o).

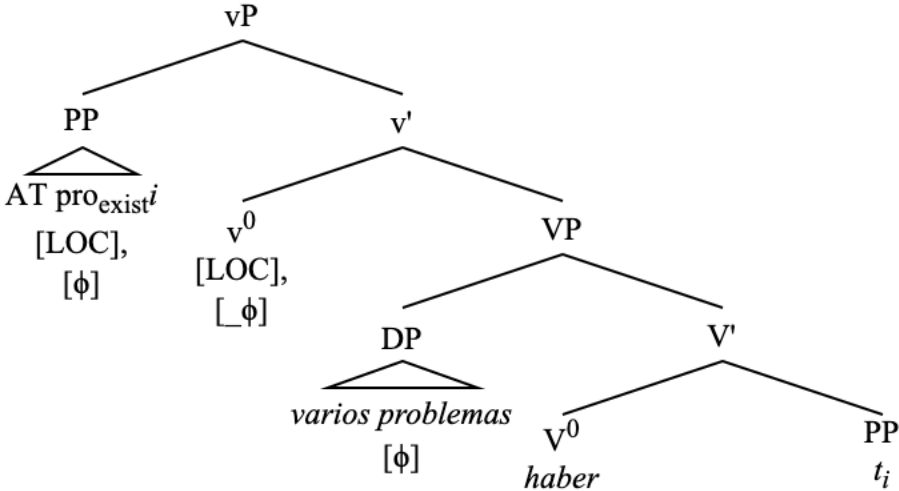
⁶ This could feasibly also be represented by a category feature, such as [P]. I see no reason to rule this out at present.

(25) v^0 with $[_{LOC}]$, $[_{\phi}]$ features takes VP as its complement



First, the probe searches for a viable goal bearing $[_{LOC}]$, the closest of which is the existential argument PP located in Comp,VP. As a result of this probing, the PP moves to Spec,vP, and the unvalued locative feature on the existential v^0 head is valued.

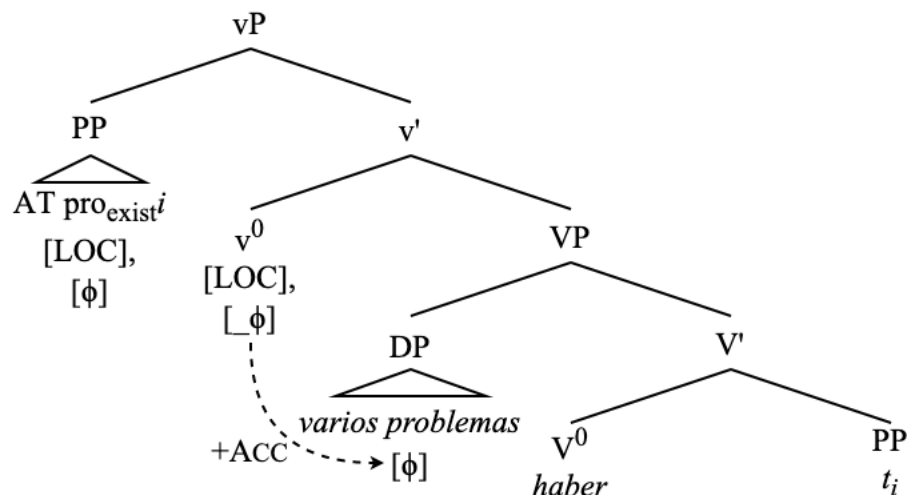
(26) Existential argument PP moves to Spec,vP



The movement of the existential argument to Spec,vP, however, does not value the phi-probe on v^0 . This is because the feature copying of a $[_{LOC}]$ feature with respect to $[_{\phi}]$ is not coarse, as $[_{LOC}]$ and $[_{\phi}]$ do not stand in a feature-geometric relation to one another.

As such, the phi-probe on v^0 initiates a search after the existential argument has moved to Spec,vP and the $[_{LOC}]$ feature on v^0 has been valued. This search assigns accusative Case to whatever the goal for phi-agreement with v^0 is, which is the associate DP.

(27) Phi-probing by v^0 leads to accusative Case assignment



While the existential argument has undergone Agree with v^0 , it has not undergone phi-agreement with v^0 . Its phi-features were not valued on v^0 . As such, the existential argument does not receive accusative Case, and it can go on to receive nominative Case by undergoing Agree with and moving into the specifier of T^0 .

It is important to note that, even though the associate DP receives accusative Case in this structure (as evidenced by the fact that it can appear as object clitic), it is still very possible for this DP to undergo phi-agreement with T^0 . This is still possible even when the associate appears as an overtly-accusative-marked object clitic.

- (28) a. Hubieron dos hombres en la fiesta (Rodríguez-Mondoñedo 2006:327)
 had.3pl two men in the party
 ‘There were two men in the party’
 b. Los hubieron
 them.ACC had.3pl
 ‘There were them’

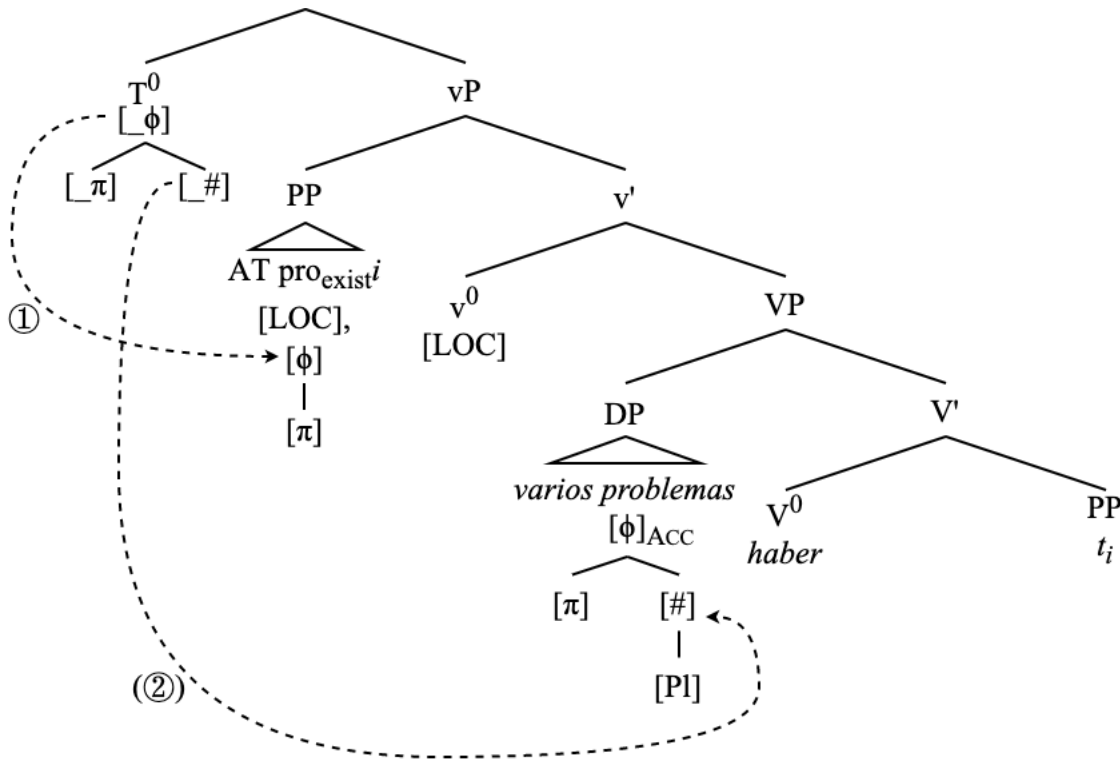
These data are complications for frameworks of Agree in which only nominative-Case-marked goals are viable candidates for undergoing phi-agreement with T^0 (Bobaljik 2008; Preminger 2014; a.m.o), as we clearly have clausal agreement tracking the features of an accusative object. There are similarly complicative data from a variety of constructions in English (Storment 2025). In fact, these data and others like them clearly demonstrate that any theory of Agree that is fed by morphological case (Moravcsik 1978; Marantz 1991; Bobaljik 2008) is not on the right track, as the presence of “dependent” Case (such as accusative) does not unilaterally block phi-agreement. As such, I see no advantage in adopting a “Case-discriminating” theory of phi-probes (Preminger 2014).

The framework of Agree used in this paper is crucially not fed by morphological case assignment, and rather supports the view that Case assignment is fed by phi-agreement (Chomsky 2000; 2001; Platzack 2006; Legate 2008; Poole 2024; a.o). As such, clauses in which verbal agreement tracks the features of an accusative object are not an issue. In these terms, it

does not even make sense to think of a Case value as something that could feed or block phi-agreement, as Case assignment is a consequence of agreement with certain functional heads. The accusative Case of the associate DP has no bearing on whether or not the associate can be Agreed with by T^0 . What allows for the associate object to be a viable goal for phi-Agree with T^0 is that it is sufficiently local to T^0 to be in its search domain, and that the only intervening phi-goal between T^0 and the associate is phi-deficient, meaning that it is possible for T^0 to initiate a search for which the intervener is not visible.

Given this information, the structure of these existential clauses at the time of probing is as follows. See this updated version of the structure in (21).

- (29) a. {Hubo/ hubieron} varios problemas
 {had.3sg/had.3pl} various problems
 ‘There {was/were} various problems’
 b. Structure of (29a)



Here, T^0 first undergoes Agree with the first viable phi-bearing goal ①, which is the existential argument in Spec,vP. As a result, the probe is valued for $[\phi]$ and $[\pi]$. Additionally, the existential argument moves to Spec,TP, and it is assigned nominative Case. If the probe only initiates one search, then singular agreement *hubo* is spelled out on the verb. If defective circumvention occurs ②, then the features of the associate DP are copied back to the probe as well, driven by a search for $[\#]$. If we conceive of functional heads like T^0 as having only a single Case feature to “give out”, then we do not need to worry about nominative Case being doubly assigned to the associate, as it would have already given its nominative Case feature to the first goal that it underwent Agree with. After all, it is certainly the case that a single goal may be Agreed with by

multiple probes without ending up with more than one Case value assigned to a single DP (Polinsky & Potsdam 2001; Polinsky 2003). The second probing cycle by T^0 also does not cause movement to Spec,TP for the simple fact that the first goal has already moved there (and this framework does not adopt multiple specifiers for the same reasons that it does not adopt equidistance).

So, it is the [LOC] feature on v^0 that orders the arguments for defective circumvention to occur with probing by T^0 , which is at the core of the agreement alternation seen with Spanish existential *haber* clauses. The formulation of Agree used here to explain this agreement alternation is radically simple, and effectively reduces to Minimal Search. It only with a probe's features and its closest goals defined in terms of asymmetrical c-command. In this framework, there is no need for Agree to be able to see information such as the morphological case of a given goal. This, along with the fact that Case assignment can be reduced to Agree itself, simplifies the conceptualization of Agree as a syntactic operation while simultaneously explaining cases of optional agreement which have traditionally posed major theoretical challenges.

After briefly defending the stance that these kind of agreement alternations should be viewed as optionality that results from the derivation of a single set of grammatical operations (section 2.4), I explain how first and second person agreement in existential *haber* clauses falls out naturally from the framework of Agree adopted here.

2.4 In defense of optionality

In SII, the tendency is to agree with the postverbal subject when that subject is third person plural. This is described by Rodríguez Mondoñedo as obligatory associate agreement, and he claims that any speaker who accepts both singular and plural agreement on the existential verb with a plural associate is actually bidialectal in SI and SII (Rodríguez Mondoñedo 2006: fn. 19).

I reject this claim on theoretical and empirical grounds. While plural agreement may be preferred by SII speakers, the vast majority (if not all) SII speakers are aware of the possibility that singular agreement is possible in the same configurations as well. Even if this is in part due to prescriptive pressure, it still results in speakers having a grammar in which they accept both singular and plural agreement with a plural associate.

Theoretically, it is not advantageous to claim that agreement optionality is a result of bidialectalism when it can be easily explained within a single system of grammatical operations. Additionally, there is no shortage of examples from native Spanish speakers online (confirmed as grammatical utterances) that show two different agreement forms in a single utterance.

- (30) aunque hubo muchas lágrimas y pérdidas, también hubieron risas... (Twitter)
 though had.3sg much tears and losses also had.3pl laughs
 'Although there was many tears and losses, there were also laughs...'
- (31) Wow, si hubo varias burbujas y seguro que las habran aún.... (Twitter)
 wow yes had.3sg various bubbles and sure that them have.FUT.3pl still...
 'Wow, yes there was various bubbles and I'm sure that they'll be there still'

- (32) No se si habrán mecheros... pero seguro q si habrá (Twitter)
 no know.1pl if have.FUT.3pl lighters but sure that yes have.FUT.3sg
 muchas risas!!
 much laughs
 ‘I don’t know if there will be lighters... but I’m sure that there will be many laughs!!’
- (33) había muchos sucesos raros ocurriendo a la vez, había-n muchos agujeros (Twitter)
 had.3sg much events rare occurring at the time, had -3pl many holes
 negros concentrados en una zona
 black concentrated in a zone
 ‘There was many strange events happening at the same time, there were many black holes concentrated in a single zone’

Speakers even use singular and plural forms of the existential verb coordinated with the same associate. Again, such sentences are very well attested online.

- (34) Siempre hubo y habrá -n habilitadores (Twitter)
 always had.3sg and have.FUT-3pl enablers
 ‘There always was and will be enablers’
- (35) En nuestra vida, ha habido y habrá -n muchas zarzas ardientes (Blog)
 in our life has.3pl had and have.FUT-3pl many bushes burning
 ‘In our life, there has been and will be many burning bushes’
- (36) Siempre hubieron y habrá víctimas que creen en ese amor (Facebook)
 always had.3pl and have.FUT.3pl victims that believe in that love
 ‘There always were and will be victims who believe in that love’

I ignore present tense *haber* in these examples as the presence of the locative clitic often prevents the expression of plural agreement (more on this in section 4).

These examples demonstrate that, for at least a non-trivial number of speakers who accept plural agreement with a plural associate, they also accept singular agreement with the same subject. Of course, code-switching is a possibility to explain the attestation of multiple agreement forms in the same utterance (especially in (30) through (33)) but it is my suspicion that not all of these kinds of examples will be compatible with the kind of structures that facilitate code-switching.

I find this bidialectal code switching explanation unlikely as, in a scenario in which SII only allows for plural agreement and SI only allows for singular agreement, there is clearly a difference in register. In situations where the two dialects would coexist, SI is more formal (hence the prescriptive influence), and SII more colloquial. For the utterances shown in (30) through (36), there is no discernable difference in register, style, or formality between the clauses showing plural agreement and those showing singular agreement.

I additionally find it implausible that this kind of agreement alteration should come about through the existence of two T^0 heads: one that leads to number agreement with a plural

associate, and one that does not, regardless of whether or not those two T^0 heads belong to different dialects (cf. Rodríguez Mondoñedo 2006: fn. 45). Aside from the issues that coordination raises, there is independent evidence to suggest that phi-probes should be uniformly structured throughout a given language (Béjar 2003; 2011; Béjar & Rezac 2003; 2009; Preminger 2012; 2014; 2019; Coon & Keine & Wagner 2017; Coon & Keine 2021; Storment 2025; a.o), despite the current pervasiveness of attributing agreement variation of this kind to the presence of multiple configurations of agreement probes in a given language (or multiple languages that a single speaker has access to) (Obata & Epstein & Baptista 2015; Obata & Epstein 2016; Georgi 2017; Puškar 2017; Halpert 2019; Hoover 2021; Fernández-Serrano 2022; Driemel 2024; Streffer 2024; a.m.o). Indeed, the uniform ordering of probing in this analysis is driven by the hierarchical structure of the phi-feature geometries: the root node [ϕ] probes first.

It is unlikely that this kind of agreement should be explained by positing the existence of two different lexical items (i.e., T^0) which have the exact same exponence and appear in the exact same contexts, or that two varieties of a language should be expected to vary only in this way. I am wary of the questions that such an analysis raises for acquisition and theory. If we can explain these cases of variation and optionality without positing additional variants of a single abstract head that a language user must acquire, I consider that a plus.

Another issue with the “multiple T^0 s” approach to this kind of variation is that, without caveats *ad infinitum*, the presence of one T^0 (one that requires number or participant agreement) over another (one that does not require number or participant agreement) driving agreement behavior in specific varieties of Spanish makes the wrong empirical predictions. For instance, it definitely does not seem to be the case that speakers of varieties of Spanish that only allow singular existential agreement with a plural associate are the same speakers who also prefer number unagreement in other scenarios where it is possible, such as impersonal *se* constructions (Ausín & Depiante 2023; Ormazabal & Romero 2024) and dative experiencer subject sentences (Fernández Serrano 2022). If the ability to do or not do number agreement were solely the result of a certain T^0 probe being present in a given language variety, then we would expect consistency across different constructions in that respect.

Furthermore, the facts on agreement variation across dialects are currently not understood well enough – and are far too nuanced and intricate – to definitively contribute agreement variation and optionality to the mere fact of switching between different dialects, and the differences between how speakers realize these options to what dialects they can be considered to be proficient in. For example, many speakers who accept plural agreement on *haber* with a third person plural associate do not accept first or second person verbal agreement, despite the suggestion by Rodríguez Mondoñedo (2006) that these two agreement options are characteristic of the same dialect. Further sources consider associate agreement in existential clauses ubiquitous in Latin America (Kany 1967; Moss 1990), despite considerable variation there, as well as considerable variation in both American and Peninsular Spanish as to which associates can trigger verbal agreement and for whom (Castillo Lluch & Octavio de Toledo y Huerta 2016).

Another example of the intricacies of this kind of agreement variation is that speakers who allow plural verbal agreement (SII) do not always allow plural agreement in the present tense, as the use of the nonstandard plural present tense indicative existential verb *hayn* (more on this in

section 4) is much more restricted than the use of plural existential verbs in other tenses, such as *habían*, *hubieron*, or *habrán*. It seems advantageous to model these agreement alternations in the syntax as the outputs of a single grammatical system, the choices between which can be independently preferred or dispreferred by speakers according to various factors and preferences external to the system that derives the agreement alternation itself, so that we do not have to posit multiple language varieties and multidialectalism for every speaker who may produce or accept more than one agreement form, especially when there is so much variation regarding which forms are accepted and produced by individuals even within a single speech community (Castillo Lluh & Octavio de Toledo y Huerta 2016 and sources therein) and it is not fully clear which agreement forms can be completely attributed to which dialects. The theoretical and descriptive advantages of severing agreement optionality from multidialectism are numerous.

The question here ultimately is where one wants to place the locus of this kind of agreement variation: in the narrow syntax, or in some external cognitive or sociolinguistic system and the necessary coexistence of multiple language varieties in a single speaker. I take the former route in this paper, where the narrow syntax derives more than one licit output in the contexts where this kind of intraspeaker agreement variation appears. While it is certainly possible that preferences for a certain form over another can be conditioned according to sociolinguistic and cognitive factors external to the narrow syntax, and given the drawbacks discussed here of necessarily conflating this kind of agreement variation to multidialectalism, it seems a major advantage to be able to attribute the mere presence of the variation to a single syntax that allows for it, while still leaving option to the possibility of sociolinguistic constraining of valid agreement realizations to account for intraspeaker and interspeaker variation.

3 Agreement interaction with [Part]-bearing associates

Notably, the agreement optionality seen with existential *haber* sentences with third person plural postverbal associates is seen in a variety of other constructions in certain varieties of Spanish, including sentences with dative experiencer structural subjects (Fernández Serrano 2022), impersonal *se* clauses (Ausín & Depiante 2023; Ormazabal & Romero 2024), postverbal subjects of certain unaccusative verb constructions (Mensching & Remberger 2006; Huidobro & Franco 2012), and specificational copular clauses.

- (37) Nos {encanta/ encanta-n} las películas de terror (Fernández Serrano 2022:9)
 us.DAT {love.3sg/love-3pl} the films of terror
 ‘We love horror movies’
- (38) Se {censuró/ censuraron} los documentos (Ormazabal & Romero 2024:445)
 se {censored.3sg/censored.3pl} the documents
 ‘The documents were censored’
- (39) {Llegó/ llegaron} grandes poderes (Mensching & Remberger 2006:198⁷)
 {arrived.3sg/arrived.3pl} grand powers
 ‘There arrived grand powers’

⁷ This example – as well as the others given in this source – of third person plural verbal agreement with a third person plural postverbal subject of an unaccusative verb is from classical/medieval Spanish; however, this

- (40) Lo que quiere {es/son} los privilegios para sus empresas (Ordóñez p.c.)
 it that wants {is/are} the privileges for his businesses
 ‘What he wants is/are privileges for his businesses’

The agreement alternations shown here in (37) through (40) can be uniformly explained under the same system of optional agreement via defective circumvention presented in section 2. Regardless of the Case feature of the postverbal argument in these cases, it can be a goal of optional number probing as long as it is in the search domain of the phi-probe on T⁰.

Notably, where there is agreement optionality with a 3pl DP, there is no optionality with a first or second person (i.e., [Part]-bearing) postverbal argument DP. If the postverbal subject bears a [Part] feature, then, for the most part⁸, the verb must show first or second person agreement.

- (41) a. Me {gusta-s/ *gusta} tú
 me.DAT {like-2sg/*like.3sg} you.NOM
 ‘I like you’
 b. Te {gusto/ *gusta} yo
 you.DAT {like.1sg/*like.3sg} I.NOM
 ‘You like me’
- (42) a. {Llega-mos/*llega-n/ *llega} nosotros
 {arrive-1pl/ *arrive-3pl/*arrive.3sg} we.NOM
 ‘We arrive’
 b. {Llegué/ *llegó} yo
 {arrived.1pl/*arrived.3pl} I.NOM
 ‘I arrived’

optionality still survives today in certain varieties of Spanish (which, to my knowledge, is not acknowledged in the literature), as evidenced by publicly available social media posts from native Spanish speakers which show not only singular verbal agreement with postverbal third person plural subjects, but singular and plural agreement forms in the same contexts within the same utterance.

⁸ The generalization shown here of obligatory [Part] agreement does not hold for impersonal *se* constructions. In impersonal *se* sentences, when there is a [Part] bearing postverbal subject, the verb obligatorily surfaces with third person singular agreement (Ormazabal & Romero 2024). In other words, the verb obligatorily does not agree with a [Part]-bearing postverbal DP. [Part]-bearing pronominal DPs must additionally appear as object clitics.

- (ii) a. *Se {censuramos/ censuraron/ censuró} nosotros (Ormazabal & Romero 2024:457)
se {censored.1pl/censored.3pl/censored.3sg} we.NOM
 b. Se nos {censuró/ *censuramos/ *censuraron}
se us.ACC {censored.3sg/*censored.1pl/*censored.3pl}
 ‘We were censured’

We know that *haber* is not like this because it is possible to have a [Part]-agreeing verb form, as is the subject of investigation in this section. Case is irrelevant here, so *haber* should not be expected to pattern in like the impersonal *se* construction in terms of agreement simply because *se* constructions also assign accusative case to the postverbal thematic subject. I believe that the difference of [Part]-agreement being blocked in the impersonal *se* construction as opposed to being allowed in the existential *haber* construction (and the other clause types shown above) lies in the fact that *se* is distinctly a third person pronominal element (Nevins 2007), which blocks further probing and agreement with a [Part]-bearing goal (Storment 2025).

- (43) a. La víctima {soy/*es} yo
 the victim {am/ *is} I.NOM
 ‘The victim is me’
 b. Los culpable-s {sois/ *son/ *es} vosotros
 the culpable-pl {are.2pl/*are.3pl/*is} vosotros
 ‘The responsible ones are y’all’

I demonstrate in this section that agreement with a postverbal [Part]-bearing associate works the same in existential *haber* clauses as it does in the constructions in (41) through (43), although the distribution of [Part]-bearing associates in existential *haber* clauses is highly constrained by the definiteness effect (Agulló 2024), which only affects the arguments of existential verbs.

In this section, I show how agreement with a [Part]-bearing postverbal argument DP is obligatory while agreement with a third person plural DP is optional under the system of defective circumvention. After discussing how the definiteness effect is a semantic restriction that rules out the presence of [Part]-bearing pronominals in existential *haber* clauses, I show that existential *haber* clauses also show obligatory agreement with a [Part]-bearing associate in the varieties of Spanish that allow optional agreement with a third person plural associate.

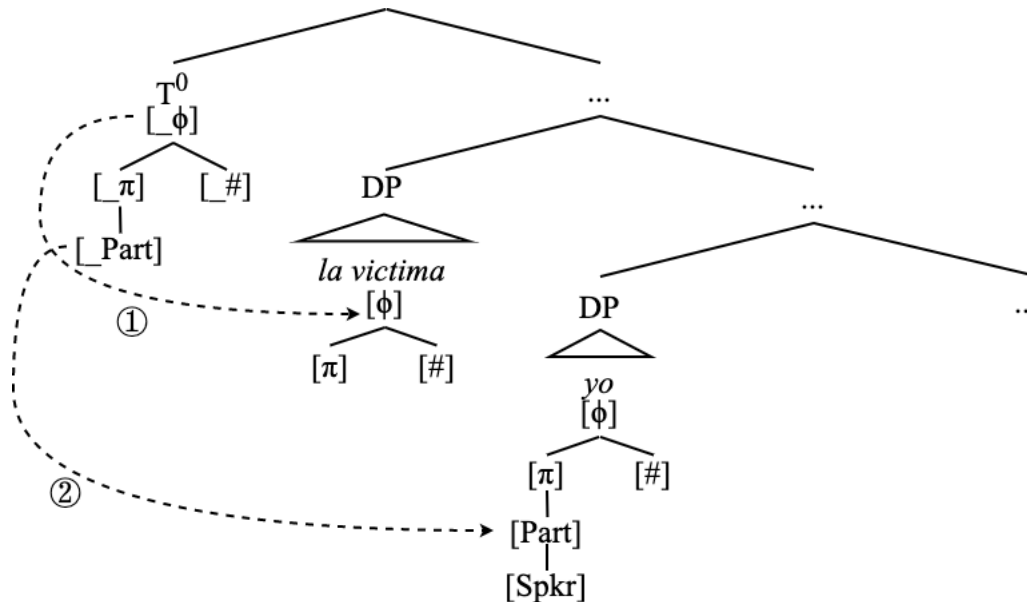
3.1 Obligatory defective circumvention with [Part]-bearing postverbal subjects

While agreement may be optional with certain postverbal argument DPs which are third person, it is obligatory to agree with a postverbal [Part]-bearing DP in Spanish. This may initially seem puzzling given the sketch in section 2 of optional agreement via defective circumvention, but, as I show here, defective circumvention can be obligatory depending on the featural specification of the probe and relevant goals in the derivation. Namely, in the case of Spanish phi-probing by T^0 , there is also a [$_Part$] probe that obligatorily searches for the closest goal in the search domain of T^0 bearing a [Part] feature, which I left out of the derivations in section 2 for the sake of exposition and simplicity as that section did not deal with any [Part]-bearing goals.

Given that a failure by a probe to value its features does not lead to a failed derivation in the case there is no matching goal in the search domain of the probe (Preminger 2014), a probe that does not undergo agreement with a [Part]-bearing goal is not an issue for the derivations in section 2 of this paper. For the examples in section 2, an obligatory search for a [Part]-bearing goal would make no difference for the derivations as there are no [Part]-bearing goals. As such, it was not necessary to indicate [Part]-probing for those derivations. Applying the knowledge from this section to the previous one would result in showing an extra step in those derivations that ultimately makes no difference in the output.

Keeping in mind that, in a feature-geometric structure, 1st and 2nd persons are represented by the presence of a [Part] feature dominated by [π], and that 1st person is represented by a [Spkr] feature dominated by [Part] then [π] (Harley & Ritter 2002; Béjar 2003; Preminger 2014; Coon & Keine 2023; Ormazabal & Romero 2024; Storment 2025; a.o), we can examine how obligatory [Part] agreement works in Spanish. See the following example from (43) whose agreement schema is given here.

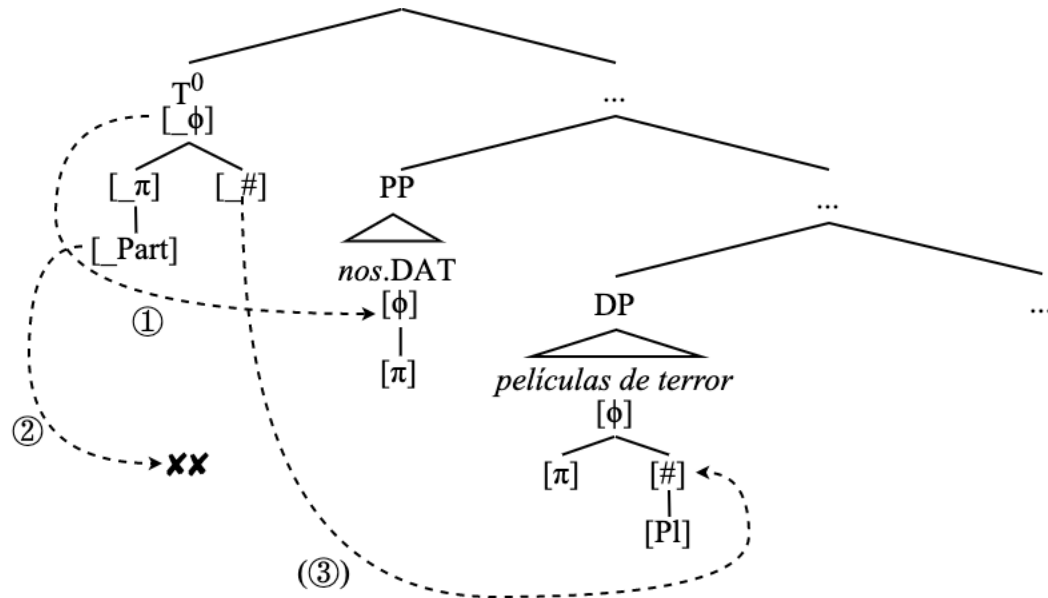
- (44) a. La víctima {soy/*es} yo
 the victim {am/*is} I.NOM
 ‘The victim is me’
 b. Structure of the probe on T⁰ and its relevant goals in (44b)



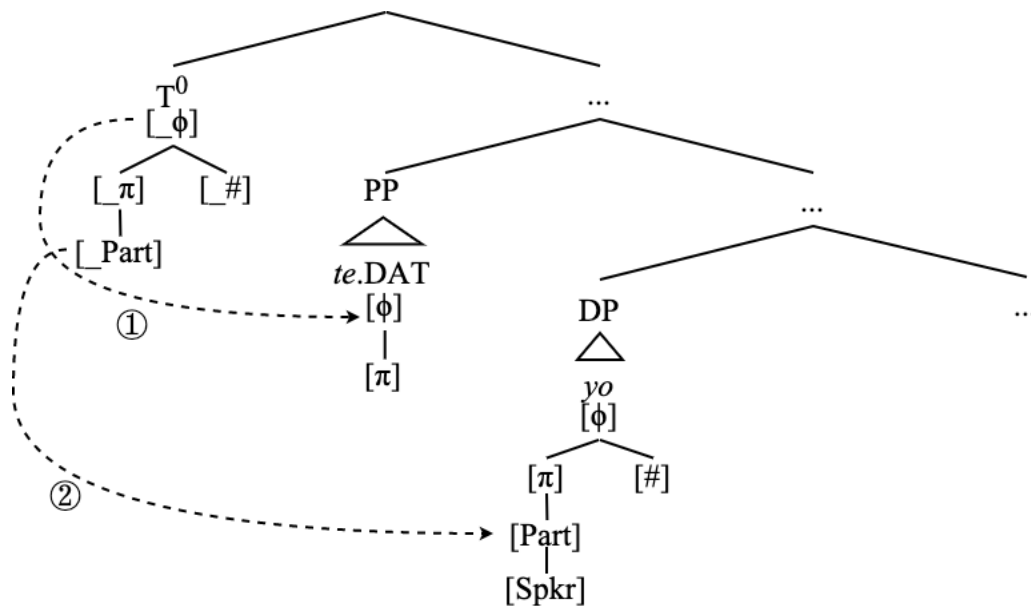
Here, defective circumvention works just as it did in section 2, the major difference being that the second cycle of probing is driven by [Part] instead of [#], and it is not optional. Indeed, the second cycle of probing here cannot be driven by number, as number probing at this point would be optional (as established in section 2), and the closer goal that T⁰ agrees with in ① values the [#] feature on the probe, so there would be no motivation to search again for [#] (and, crucially, agreement probing cannot stop in this example at ①, for third person singular verbal agreement is ungrammatical).

Indeed, this is the case in other areas, even where optional number probing is possible, hence why *Nos encanta películas* (37) is grammatical for some speakers, but *Te gusta yo* (41) is grammatical for no speakers. See the following schematizations of Agree in these examples.

- (45) a. Nos {encanta/ encanta-n} las películas de terror
 us.DAT {love.3sg/love-3pl} the films of terror
 ‘We love horror movies’
 b. Probe-goal structure of (45a)



- (46) a. Te {gusto/ *gusta} yo
 you.DAT {like.1sg/*like.3sg} I.NOM
 ‘You like me’
 b. Probe-goal structure of (46a)



Keeping in mind that datives are contained in a PP shell that makes them visible to the phi-probe on T^0 as phi-deficient in the same way that the existential argument PP is (Rezac 2004; 2008;

Bjorkman & Zeijlstra 2019; Fernández-Serrano 2022), we see two cases here of defective circumvention: one optional (45) and one obligatory (46).

In the first example, optional defective circumvention is driven by a [_#] feature on the probe. This works just the same as optional number probing in section 2, indicated in (45) with step ③. The search driven by [_{Part}] – shown with the optional ② in (45) – finds nothing, as there is no [_{Part}]-bearing goal in the search domain of T⁰.

In the second example, obligatory defective circumvention is driven by a [_{Part}] feature on the probe. The search for a [_{Part}]-bearing goal – shown with ② in (46) – finds the postverbal first person singular subject *yo*. Given that this obligatory search for a [_{Part}]-bearing goal also values the [_#] feature on the probe (since *yo* is specified for number as well), there is no possibility to have an optional search for [_#] in this derivation.

The framework presented here rests on the fact that defective circumvention via number probing is *optional*, while defective circumvention via participant probing is *obligatory*. This claim is certainly worthy of motivation, as it is not immediately obvious why this should be the case.

Participant agreement carries unique stipulation that aren't seen with other kinds of phi-features (Nichols 2001; Ormazabal & Romero 2001; Béjar & Rezac 2003; Baker 2008; Preminger 2014; Pancheva & Zubizarreta 2017; Raynaud 2020; a.o). Namely, while the failure of most phi-features to participate in an Agree relation does not result in ungrammaticality (Preminger 2014), the failure of a participant feature to participate in an Agree relation does in fact lead to ungrammaticality in a variety of circumstances. This has been formalized in various ways, most notably as the following axiom (Béjar & Rezac 2003).

- (47) *Person Licensing Condition (PLC)* (Béjar & Rezac 2003:53)
Interpretable 1st/2nd-person features must be licensed by entering into an Agree relation with an appropriate functional category.

There is a significant body of work that deals with the underlying nature of the PLC and how best to model it in the syntax (see citations above). Serious inquiry into the question of why something like the PLC should exist in the first place may eventually force us to reconsider the very nature of person probing – and perhaps, ultimately, all phi-probing – as a whole (see Pancheva & Zubizarreta 2017; Raynaud 2020); however, it is sufficient for our purposes here to acknowledge the existence of the PLC as a condition that drives obligatory person probing.

The PLC, then, is “rooted in the inherent indexicality of 1st and 2nd person[s]... and the syntacticization of the discourse context” (Raynaud 2020:113). In other words, as indexical features, 1st and 2nd person features must be licensed via agreement in order to be syntactically linked to a discourse context. As [_{Participant}] is indexical in a way that [_#] is not, this condition only applies to [_{Part}]-bearing elements.

Following Storment (2025:74) and the implications of work by Preminger (2011:931) and Coon & Keine (2021:661), I adopt the view that the PLC expressed through the requirement of a [_{Part}] feature on a phi-probe to initiate a search, as opposed to a requirement that could be

marked on any potential goal. As it is stated as an axiom, the PLC should hold universally, which is problematic for languages such as French or English in which postverbal [Part]-bearing subjects cannot be agreed with. Compare the following examples of specificational copular clauses to the sentence in (44).

(48) La victime c' {est/*suis} {moi/ *je} (French)
 the victim that' {is/ *am} {me.ACC/*I.NOM}
 'The victim is me'

(49) The victim {is/*am} {me/*I} (English)

Having shown that there is no reason to posit Case-discriminating phi-probes à la Preminger (2014)⁹, the difference between Spanish and French/English in this regard – namely, that Spanish requires [Part] agreement in the exact same configuration in which it is disallowed in French and English – must come down to the nature of phi-probing in these languages. I further see no reason why these French and English examples should be grammatical at all if the PLC is a requirement that applies to [Part] features on potential goals instead of [_{Part}] features on probes. The parametric difference between Spanish and French/English can be explained if we assume that the locus of the PLC is a [_{Part}] feature on probes that drive obligatory searches for [Part]-bearing goals, and that Spanish T⁰ contains this feature, while English/French T⁰ lacks it.

Storment (2025) connects the availability of a [_{Part}] probe on T⁰ to the null subject parameter, showing that languages in which T⁰ can function pronominally (Rizzi 1982) encode the phi-probe on the head with an indexical feature such as [_{Part}]. I echo this observation here.

In sum, [_{Part}] probing drives agreement via defective circumvention with a postverbal [Part]-bearing goal in Spanish, which is obligatory due to the syntacticized discourse requirement of the PLC. As for languages such as French and English where there is no requirement for postverbal [Part]-bearing subjects to be agreed with in the same situations where agreement with them is obligatory in Spanish, this is because these languages lack a [_{Part}] probe on T⁰; as such, there is no PLC-like requirement in these configurations as the feature which implements the PLC is simply absent from the configuration.

I now demonstrate that obligatory [_{Part}] probing by T⁰ is also a feature of existential *haber* clauses, and that the seeming scarcity of verbal agreement with a participant goal in these constructions is due to the fact that [Part]-bearing pronominals are disallowed under the strong definiteness effect that Spanish has.

⁹ Indeed, a Case-discriminating probe story also fails for English sentences of this variety in which verbal phi-agreement with an accusative DP is very much possible. See Storment (2025) for a detailed discussion of these cases in English.

- (iii) a. What their families really need are them
 b. All I miss are them
 c. When I walk into the store, all I see are them
- (iv) a. There are them that cannot sing, and them that cannot weep
 b. There were them and there was us, and he never saw it any differently

3.2 The definiteness effect and indefinite [Part]-bearing associates

[Part]-bearing pronominal DPs are banned as associates of existential *haber* sentences, regardless of verbal agreement or Case assignment.

- (50) a. *Habré yo
have.FUT.1pl I.NOM
int: 'There will be me'
b. *Hubiste tú
had.3pl you.NOM
int: 'There was you'
c. *Hubimos nosotros
had.1pl we.NOM
int: 'There was us'
d. *Habéis vosotros
have.2pl y'all.NOM
int: 'There are y'all'
- (51) *{Me/ te/ nos/ os} había (Rodríguez Mondoñedo 2006:341)
{me.ACC/you.ACC/us.ACC/y'all.ACC} had.3sg
int: 'There was me/you/us/y'all'

Third person (non-[Part]-bearing) pronominals are also banned as associates here.

- (52) a. *Había ella
had.3sg she.NOM
int: 'There was her'
b. *{Había/ había-n} ellos
{had.3sg/had -3pl} they.NOM
Int: 'There was/were them'

In fact, any definite DP, regardless of its person features or status as a pronominal is banned from the associate position in existential *haber* sentences.

- (53) a. *Ha -y Inés en la habitación
have-LOC Inés in the room
int: 'There is Inés in the room'
b. *Ha -y el libro en la habitación
have-LOC the book in the room
int: 'There is the book in the room'

Thus, the examples in (50) are not banned because of any restriction on [Part] agreement in existential clauses, but because of a strong definiteness effect that prevents definite and/or specific DPs from appearing as associates (Milsark 1974; 1977; Agulló 2024).

The definiteness effect has received much attention crosslinguistically (Milsark 1977; 1979; Safir 1982; 1987; Szabolcsi 1986a; b; Heim 1987; Diesing 1992; Abbott 1993; Rigau 1993; 1997;

Moro 1997; Keenan 2003; Sheehan 2016; Fischer & Kupsich 2016; Kayne 2016a; 2018, Agulló 2024; a.m.o), though still remains mysterious and (at the time of writing this) is without a consensus explanation. A cohesive ontological explanation of the phenomenon is far beyond the scope of this paper, but it is important to note that the definiteness effect is responsible for the apparent restriction on [Part]-bearing associates in existential *haber* sentences, and that having a [Part]-bearing associate – and subsequent [Part] verbal agreement – is entirely possible.

There are (at least) two pervasive explanations of the definiteness effect in the literature. The first is a semantic account of the definiteness effect in which the semantic derivation of existential sentences combined with a definite arguments creates a kind of infelicitous unintended contextual tautology (Szabolcsi 1986a; b; Abrusán 2019; Kiss 2023).

The second main account of the definiteness effect is one in which the restriction of definite DPs comes out of the narrow syntax via some mechanism like the assignment of partitive Case to the associate DP (Belletti 1987; 1988; Chomsky 1995), which is possible only with indefinites (though perhaps something like partitivity can ultimately be reduced a semantic property such as presupposition (Diesing 1992)).

Regardless of the story – syntactic or semantic – of the definiteness effect that one adopts, it bears no relevance to the ability of a probe to access the [Part] feature of an indefinite or nonspecific DP associate. In a Case-based explanation of the definiteness effect, an indefinite partitive associate DP can still serve as a goal for T⁰ as bearing a “marked” Case value does not render a given DP invisible to phi-probing.

In Spanish, [Part] verbal agreement can appear in the presence of a non-pronominal lexical DP that is not overtly marked as first or second person (Bosque & Moreno 1984; Hurtado 1985; Taraldsen 1995; Torrego 1996; Ordóñez & Treviño 1999; Ordóñez 2000; Saab 2006; 2013; Villa García 2010; Höhn 2014; a.o).

- (54) a. Los estudiantes defende-mos la universidad pública (Saab 2013:192)
 the students defend -1pl the university public
 ‘We the students defend the public university’
 b. Los estudiantes defende-is la universidad pública
 the students defend -2pl the university public
 ‘Y’all the students defend the public university’

In these configurations, first person plural agreement on the verb indicates that the speaker is among the set of individuals that the subject DP refers to (54a), and second person plural verbal agreement indicates that the addressee is among the set of individuals that the subject DP refers to (54b). This phenomenon is not possible with singular DPs or third person pronominals.

- (55) a. *El estudiante definiendo la universidad pública (Saab 2013:198)
the student defend.1sg the university public
int: ‘The student (me) defends the public university’
b. *El estudiante defiendes la universidad pública
the student defend.2sg the university public
int: ‘The student (you) defends the public university’
c. *Ellos defiende{-mos/is} la universidad pública
they.NOM defend {-1pl/ 2pl} the university public
int: ‘They (us) defend the public university’

There are competing analyses of this phenomenon in Spanish: one in which there is a null subject pronoun with a [Part] feature distinct from the lexical subject DP (which lacks any [Part] feature) that controls verbal agreement (Bosque & Moreno 1995; Hurtado 1985; Suñer 1988; Contreras 1991; Olarrea 1996; Torrego 1996; Rodrigues 2008; a.o), and another in which the [Part] feature is actually contained on the lexical subject DP and there is no empty pronominal elsewhere in the structure (Saab 2006; 2013; Höhn 2014; also suggested in Rodríguez Mondoñedo 2006). I adopt the latter position to explain the fact that these non-pronominal lexical DPs can also trigger [Part] agreement in existential *haber* sentences in SII.

- (56) a. Habe-mos dos estudiantes en la clase (Rodríguez Mondoñedo 2006:343)
have -1pl two students in the class
‘There are two of us students in the class’
b. Habe-is dos estudiantes en la clase
have -2pl two students in the class
‘There are of y’all students in the class’

As Rodríguez Mondoñedo (2006:344) diligently points out, we cannot explain the agreement data in (56) as the result of a null first or second person pronominal in the existential clause, as first or second pronominals are not allowed in existential *haber* clauses at all (50)-(51). This fact heavily suggests that an analysis in which the non-pronominal DP itself bears the [Part] features is on the right track¹⁰. In this analysis, I consider examples such as the ones in (56) to be derived from the same mechanism of obligatory defective circumvention driven by a [_{Part}] probe that derives the examples in (41) and (42).

3.3 [Part] agreement in existential clauses

In the situation in which we have an indefinite [Part]-bearing non pronominal DP with a necessary [Part] interpretation as the associate of an existential *haber* clause, we get obligatory agreement in varieties of Spanish that allow agreement with an associate at all (i.e., SII).

Before presenting the derivation, it is necessary to defend the position that this kind of agreement seen in (56) is in fact obligatory, because there is a sense in which it could be viewed as optional (though, as I show, that view would be inaccurate).

¹⁰ For a detailed account of how exactly a non-pronominal morphologically third person DP can come to have a [Part] feature, I defer the reader to Saab (2006) and Höhn (2014). The exact details of the analysis are not necessary to go over here as they have been worked out by others, and it is sufficient for our purposes to be aware of the fact that a DP such as *los estudiantes* in (56) is visible to the phi-probe on T⁰ as bearing a [Part] feature.

The following utterances are all grammatical in SII, and indeed their interpretations are very similar to one another.

- (57) a. Había-mos dos estudiantes en la clase
 had -1pl two students in the class
 b. Había dos estudiantes en la clase
 had.3sg two students in the class
 c. Había-n dos estudiantes en la clase
 had -3pl two students in the class
 ‘There was/were two students in the class’

Given their similarities, and given the attestation of optional agreement in existential clauses, it may be tempting to assume that all three examples in (57) are optional realizations of the same underlying structure. There is one crucial difference, however, between the (a) example and the (b)-(c) examples that sets the (a) example apart as a different configuration, which is that the associate in (a) necessarily has a first person interpretation. While a first person associate interpretation could be contextually coaxed out of (b) and (c), it is not necessarily there to begin with. A necessary first person interpretation here necessarily means that agreement will surface as first person plural.

The first person interpretation of (57a) is uncancellable with additional context. The fact that an attempt to cancel this interpretation leads to infelicity is evidence of the necessity of the first person interpretation of the associate.

- (58) Había-mos dos estudiantes en la clase (#y yo no era uno de ellos)
 had -1pl two students in the class (#and I no was one of them)
 int: ‘There were two of us students in the class (and I was not one of them)’

Meanwhile, while a first person associate interpretation can be coerced with (57b) and (c), it is certainly not the standard interpretation of the utterances, and it can just as easily be refuted.

- (59) a. {Había/ había-n} dos estudiantes en la clase (y yo era uno de ellos)
 {had.3sg/had -3pl} two students in the class (and I was one of them)
 ‘There was/were two students in the class (and I was one of them)’
 b. {Había/ había-n} dos estudiantes en la clase (y yo no era uno de ellos)
 {had.3sg/had -3pl} two students in the class (and I not was one of them)
 ‘There was/were two students in the class (and I was not one of them)’

Additionally, the fact that a first person interpretation can be contextually coerced with DPs that cannot even bear a first person feature to begin with is evidence that the contextual coercion in (59) bears nothing on the featural makeup of the DP in question.

- (61) Había un estudiante en la clase (y de hecho era yo)
 had.3sg a student in the class (and of fact was I)
 ‘There was a student in the class (and in fact it was me)’

This is true outside of existential clauses as well.

- (62) Un estudiante {leyó/ *leí} el libro (y de hecho el estudiante fui yo)
a student {read.3sg/*read.1sg} the book (and of fact the student was I)
'A student read the book (and in fact it was me)'

As such, the fact that a first person interpretation of morphologically third person existential associate DPs that do not trigger obligatory first person agreement on the verb can be contextually coerced with additional information does not indicate the presence of first person features on the DP itself. What is clear, though, is that a necessary first person interpretation on an associate DP that cannot be cancelled is necessarily associated with first person plural verbal agreement in SII varieties of Spanish that allow associate agreement in the first place.

Another piece of evidence showing that [Part] agreement in these cases is truly obligatory is what we see in coordinated verbal structures with a single associate. In these cases, which I briefly introduced in section 2.4, two coordinated TPs – each with their own T⁰ head (Burton & Grimshaw 1992; McNally 1992) – share a single associate. As there are two distinct tense heads, each verb may have its own tense value.

- (63) Nunca en la historia hubo y habrá algo así
never in the history had.3pl and have.FUT.3pl something so
'Never in history was there or will there ever be something like this'

Additionally, the existence of two distinct T⁰ heads in these coordinate structures means that there are two phi-probes. As such, an optional operation such as number probing for defective circumvention is predicted to be optional for each coordinated T⁰ probe, meaning that we expect to see examples of different phi-agreement relations being borne out on each coordinated T⁰ head that shares a third person plural associate, number agreement with which is optional. This is attested and judged grammatical by native speakers. See the relevant examples from section 2.4, repeated here.

- (64) Siempre hubo y habrá -n habilitadores (Twitter)
always had.3sg and have.FUT-3pl enablers
'There always was and will be enablers'

- (65) En nuestra vida, ha habido y habrá -n muchas zarzas ardientes (Blog)
in our life has.3pl had and have.FUT-3pl many bushes burning
'In our life, there has been and will be many burning bushes'

- (66) Siempre hubieron y habrá víctimas que creen en ese amor (Facebook)
always had.3pl and have.FUT.3pl victims that believe in that love
'There always were and will be victims who believe in that love'

Now, if agreement with a [Part] bearing associate were also optional, we should expect that similar mismatches in the relevant type of coordinate structures in which one existential verb shows third person singular agreement and the other shows [Part] agreement would be attested

and similarly judged as grammatical, but they are not. Let us first see some grammatical examples, which are judged as such by native speakers and well-attested on social media.

- (67) Sin duda en mi familia solo *habe-mos* y *habre -mos* mujeres (Twitter)
 without doubt in my family only have-1pl and have.FUT-1pl women
 ‘Without a doubt in my family there only are and will be us women’
- (68) *Hubimos* y *habe-mos* miles de mexicanos con un talento... (Facebook)
 had.1pl and have-1pl thousands of mexicans with a talent...
 ‘There were and are thousands of us Mexicans with talent...’
- (69) *Había-mos* y *habre -mos* muchos tratando y luchando por liberar -los (Twitter)
 had -1pl and have.FUT-1pl many trying and fighting for liberate-them
 ‘There were and are many of us trying and fighting to liberate them’

The verbs not matching here in agreement is degraded if not outright ungrammatical (though one predicts considerable variation on speakers’ judgments here as well).

- (70) ??/*Sin duda en mi familia solo *habe-mos* y *habrá* mujeres
 without doubt in my family only have-1pl and have.FUT.3sg women
 int: ‘Without a doubt in my family there only are and will be us women’
- (71) ??/**Hubo* y *habe-mos* miles de mexicanos con un talento...
 had.3sg and have-1pl thousands of mexicans with a talent...
 int: ‘There was and are thousands of us Mexicans with talent...’
- (72) ??/**Había* y *habre -mos* muchos tratando y luchando por liberar -los
 had.3sg and have.FUT-1pl many trying and fighting for liberate-them
 int: ‘There were and are many of us trying and fighting to liberate them’

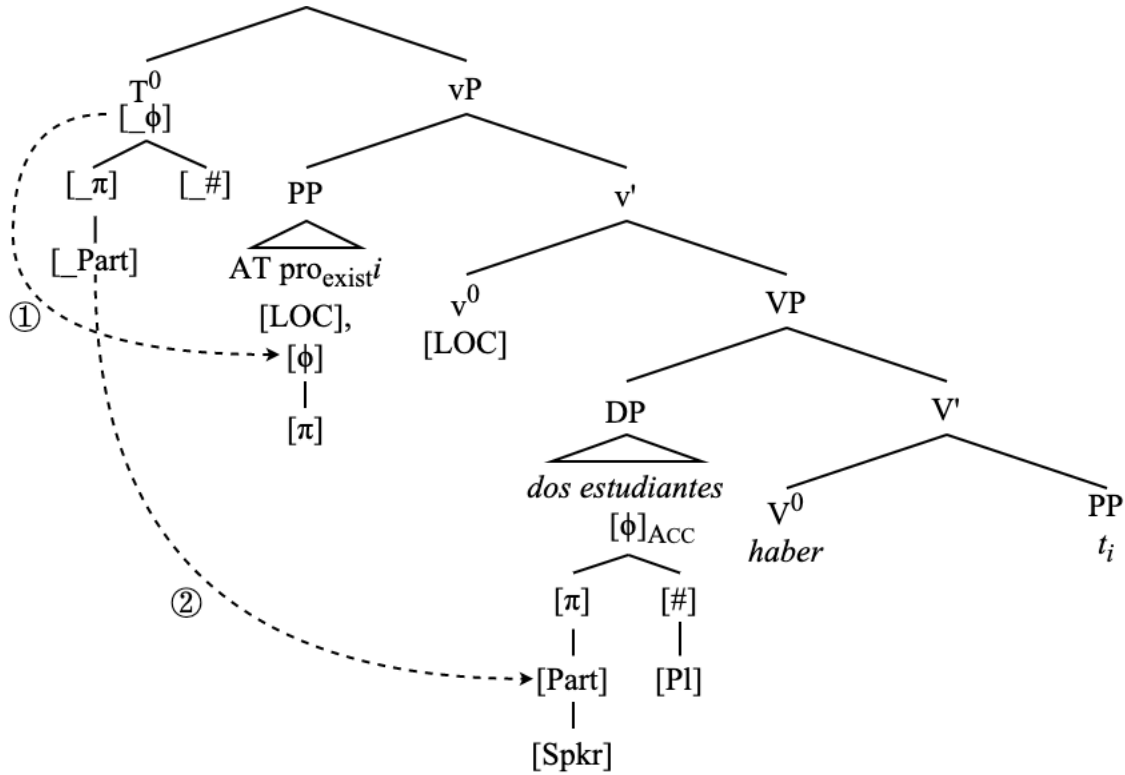
The impossibility¹¹ of having a mismatch of verbal agreement in these coordinate structures when the verbs share a first person plural associate when number agreement mismatches are very much possible shows that [Part] probing in existential *haber* clauses is obligatory, just as it is elsewhere in Spanish.

Given these considerations, we can see now the full derivation of existential sentences that contain a [Part]-bearing associate. Here I show the full structure of the following existential clause at the time of phi-probing by T⁰, at which point the existential argument has already

¹¹ There is a marginal salient interpretation of the sentences in (70) to (72) in which the associates status as a set containing the speaker is sensitive to the tense information conveyed on the coordinated verbs. In (72), for instance, a potential interpretation stands to be that *muchos* ‘many’ refers to a set of individuals that did not contain the speaker in the past (as indicated by third person singular past *había*), but will contain the speaker in the future (as indicated by first person plural future *habremos*). As for a possibility in which the associate denotes a set which contains the speaker in all times indicated by the coordinated verbs, these examples stand out as significantly degraded or completely rejected when compared to the (64) to (66) type sentences as well as the (67) to (69) type sentences.

moved to Spec,vP as motivated by the [_{LOC}] feature on v^0 , and the associate has received accusative Case.

- (73) a. Habe-mos dos estudiantes (en la clase)
have-1pl two students (in the class)
‘There were two of us students (in the class)’
b. Structure of (73a)



Just as with the derivations we have previously seen, T⁰ starts out by initiating a search for the closest goal bearing [ϕ], which is the existential argument in Spec,vP (indicated by ①). This search causes the existential argument PP to receive nominative Case and move to Spec,TP. It also causes the features of the existential argument [ϕ][π] to be copied to the probe.

At this point, there are two remaining probing features: [Part] and [$\#$]. [Part] obligatorily searches first because of the discourse requirement of the PLC, at which point it finds the closest goal bearing a [Part] feature, which is the associate DP *dos estudiantes* ‘the students’. This is shown by ②. This causes the feature-geometry containing [Part][Spkr] and [$\#$] to be copied to T⁰, thus valuing the remaining probing features on the head. There is no optional number probing because [$\#$] was valued by the search for [Part], and this probing cycle has caused obligatory defective circumvention to obtain.

As such, we end up with first person plural verbal inflection that obligatorily agrees with the first person plural postverbal associate. Since defective circumvention here is driven by a search for [Part], it is obligatory, unlike the defective circumvention shown in section 2. The probing by T⁰

shown here in (73) is identical to that which was presented in (46), though there are some unique quirks of the existential *haber* clauses, mainly having to do with the verb itself, that are worthy of discussion. I do so in the following section.

4 Some morphological idiosyncrasies of existential *haber*

There are several morphological irregularities regarding the existential verb *haber*, especially if we take into consideration language varieties which are considered colloquial or prescriptively incorrect (Moss 1990; RAE 2025). In this section, I explain these quirks of *haber* and show how they naturally follow from my analysis of agreement in this construction. These irregularities are: the appearance of the locative agreement clitic *-y* with the third person singular present tense form of the verb, the fact that the first person plural present tense verb form is *habemos* instead of the form *hemos*, and the existence of the nonstandard third person plural present tense agreement form *hayn*.

4.1 The locative subject clitic

The present tense indicative form of existential *haber* involves the necessary presence of a locative agreement clitic *-y*.

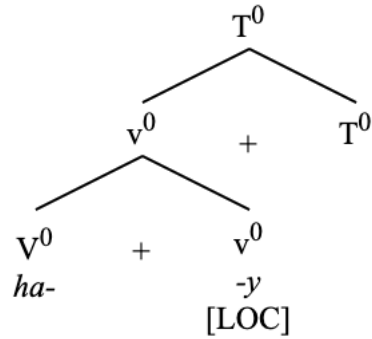
- (74) No ha *-(y)* nadie como tú
 not has*(-LOC) nobody like you.NOM
 ‘There is no one like you’

This locative clitic is a linguistic “fossil” (Levinstein Rodríguez 2021) of a locative clitic that was more productive in older varieties of Spanish, but has disappeared from all contexts other than this one. The clitic is related to French *y* (Henry 1974; Kayne 2004; 2010), Italian *ci* (Moro 1997; Tortora 2014), and Catalan *hi* (Fabra 1956; Bonet 1991; Rigau 1982), languages historically related to Spanish in which the locative clitic is more productive still. In this paper, I do not explore diachronic explanations of why *-y* is restricted to this single context in contemporary Spanish, though I do show how its presence and effects on agreement are explained by analysis of existential *haber* clauses presented thus far.

The presence of the locative clitic is said to block phi-agreement with an associate (Fernández Soriano 1999; Rodríguez Mondoñedo 2006), but that is not the whole story. I analyze this locative clitic as a subject agreement clitic (Taraldsen 1992; Ordóñez 2000; Ordóñez & Treviño 1999) that is located more closely to the verbal root head than phi-agreement affixes, which is why it can affect the expression of phi-agreement morphemes.

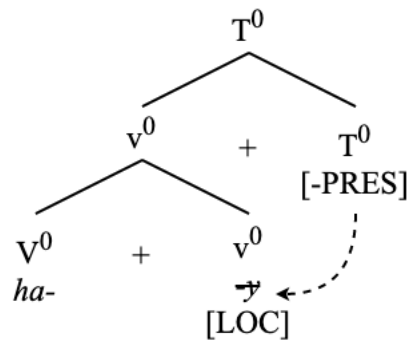
This locative clitic appears on v^0 , given that v^0 is where the existential verb’s [LOC] probe is located. Thus, given the Mirror Principle as it pertains head movement and affix ordering (Baker 1985; 1988; Harley 2009), the locative clitic is located closer to the verbal root than phi-agreement affixes, which are located on T^0 . See the following structure, keeping in mind that the locative clitic only appears on a [LOC]-bearing v^0 in the environment of unmarked tense (i.e., present indicative).

- (75) Structure of existential *hay* after head movement (*V-to-v-to-T*)



In marked tense environments (i.e., non-present or non-indicative), the locative clitic is not spelled out. As such, forms such as **hubo-y* ‘had-LOC’, **habrá-y* ‘have.FUT-LOC’, or **haya-y* ‘have.SUBJ-LOC’ are not possible. I indicate marked tense environments below with a feature called [-PRES], which I mean as non-present or non-indicative tense environments.

- (76) Spellout of the locative clitic in marked tense environments¹²



In Spanish, for the most part, present tense agreement morphemes combine directly with the verb’s theme vowel (or directly to the root). When there is another clitic intervening between the root/theme vowel and the present tense agreement morpheme, this leads in at least some varieties of Spanish (such as SI) to the impossibility of expressing a phi-agreement morpheme as well. See the following table, keeping in mind that 1sg and 2sg associates are not licit in this construction in the first place.

- (77) Licit phi-agreement morphemes following locative clitic in SI

	Verb root	Loc clitic	Phi-agr
1sg	ha-	-y	*-o
2sg			*-s
3sg			Ø
1pl			*-mos
2pl			*-is
3pl			*-n

¹² I do not indicate in this structure on which head the marked tense morphemes are spelled out. I do not consider such a detail extremely relevant for this analysis, so long as the locative clitic is not spelled out with marked tenses.

Perhaps it is the case that in varieties like SI the presence of *-y* blocks phi agreement, but that is certainly not the case in all varieties of Spanish, though the presence of the locative clitic does lead to some irregularities with verbal phi-agreement.

In fact, it is worth considering that the agreement variation seen with existential *haber* and the preference of some speakers for only non-agreeing forms is at least in part conditioned by the preference to not have an intervening agreement clitic between the verbal root or theme vowel and the phi-agreement morpheme. Thus, the difference between SI and SII with respect to agreement in existential *haber* clauses (at least in the present tense) would be explained not via the difference in the possibilities for phi-probing in the two language varieties, but via whether the phi-agreement morphemes have the ability to combine directly to something other than the verbal root and/or theme vowel, such as the locative clitic. In the language varieties where phi-agreement morphemes cannot do this, any overt expression of tense morphology would be filtered out.

As for varieties of Spanish in which the presence of the locative clitic does block the expression of associate phi-agreement, I demonstrate that the cooccurrence of phi-agreement morphemes along with the overt locative clitic is very much a possibility.

- (78) Licit phi-agreement morphemes following locative clitic when associate agreement morphology is permitted

	Verb root	Loc clitic	Phi-agr
1sg	<i>ha-</i>	<i>-y</i>	*-<i>o</i>
2sg			*-<i>s</i>
3sg			Ø
1pl			<i>-mos</i>
2pl			<i>-is</i>
3pl			<i>-n</i>

It would be incorrect to claim that phi-agreement affixes cannot follow the *-y* locative clitic, as this is attested in many varieties of Spanish with the nonstandard form *hayn* for third person plural agreement. This is the focus of section 4.2.

In section 4.3, I argue that it is also the case for [Part]-agreeing present tense indicative forms of existential *haber* that they contain an locative clitic that intervenes between the verb root and the phi-agreement morphemes, this is just not transparently seen in the way that it is with *hayn*.

4.2 Nonstandard third person plural agreement *hayn*

It is not the case that the presence of the locative clitic blocks phi-agreement in all cases. The nonstandard form *hayn*, which has been called a case of “extreme innovation” (Santos & De la Mora Gutiérrez 2022:458), is perhaps the most obvious example of phi-agreement morphology appearing following the locative clitic. Despite many sources only acknowledging the existence of *hayn* in American varieties of Spanish (Kany 1967; Lapesa 1980; Moss 1990; De Mello 1991; Fábregas & Gallego 2014; a.o), *hayn* is attested in European varieties of Spanish as well (Fábregas 2022a; RAE 2025). Even in varieties of Spanish where *habemos* and *habéis* – also nonstandard forms of the present tense existential verb – are more or less standard, *hayn*

continues to be heavily stigmatized and associated with low prestige (Castillo Lluch & Octavio de Toledo y Huerta 2016).

Although they all show third plural agreement, forms such as *habían*, *hayán*, *hubieron*, and *habrán* are much more frequently attested and accepted than *hayn*. Many speakers of many varieties of Spanish accept the former forms, but not *hayn*. To my knowledge, there are no speakers who accept only *hayn* but not the former forms. This is because the possibility of having a form like *hayn* is predicated upon allowing plural agreement, and, among the plural agreement forms, *hayn* is the most marked as it involves the phi-agreement affix combining with the locative clitic and not directly to the verb itself.

While it may seem initially as if the locative clitic and the phi-agreement morpheme are competing for the same position based on a surface-level comparison between the existential *hay* and the third person plural auxiliary form *han*, it follows from the analysis presented thus far that the locative clitic *-y* does not appear in the same position as phi-agreement morphemes. In fact, the very presence of a phi-agreement morpheme cooccurring with the locative clitic in the form *hayn* is direct evidence that these two morphemes do not occupy the same position (see the structure below in (82)). Rather, the locative clitic appears on v^0 in the position that would otherwise host a theme vowel.

A theme vowel refers to the *-e-* seen in the infinitival form of existential *hab-e-r*, and I adopt the view that theme vowels are “syntactic objects which constitute the spell out of projections that define a lexical verb” (Fábregas 2022b:2) (Picallo 1991; Kayne 2016b; Taraldsen Medová & Wiland 2019). For our purposes, it is sufficient to assume that this projection is vP, the same projection whose head has a [$_LOC$] feature with existential *haber*.

If there were no [$_LOC$] feature on the vP existential *haber*, we might expect to see a theme vowel on the verb in the present tense, but no such thing is possible.

- (79) a. *Hab -e una persona
 have-ThV a person
 int: ‘There is a person’
 b. *Hab -e (-n) dos personas
 have-ThV(-3pl) two people
 int: ‘There were two people’

Instead, the existential vP head is realized as *-y* because of the [$_LOC$] feature on v^0 .

- (80) a. Ha -y una persona
 has-LOC a person
 ‘There is a person’
 b. Ha -y (-n) dos personas
 has-LOC(-3pl) two people
 int: ‘There were two people’

The root surfacing as *hab-* or *ha-* is simple allomorphy. Looking at the entire verbal paradigm for *haber* (as an existential or auxiliary), *hab-* appears to be the form that appears in the presence of a theme vowel or tense morpheme, with *ha-* appearing elsewhere.

The lack of a theme vowel in the unmarked tense forms of auxiliary *haber* (with the exception of second person singular *habéis*, which I return to in the following subsection) can be explained by the fact that auxiliary verbs do not project a vP, and as such, their structure does not involve a head that would be a candidate to host a theme vowel¹³.

The fact that the theme vowel cannot be spelled out in the presence of the locative clitic is crucial to explain what we see not only with *hayn*, but also with the impossibility of **ha* or **habe* as a third person singular agreement form of existential *haber*.

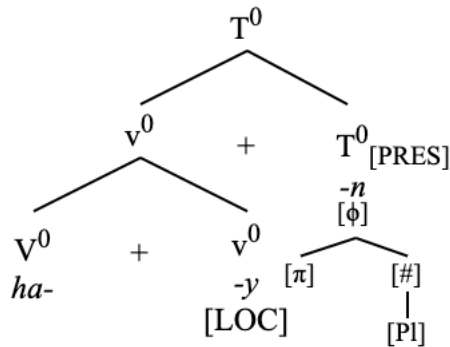
- (81) a. [TP -n [vP [LOC] -y [vP ha(b)]]] → *hay(n)*
 b. [TP -n [vP -e [vP ha(b)]]] → **habe(n)*

Further supporting evidence of this analysis in which the locative clitic appears on a head intervening between the verbal root and the phi-agreement morpheme – the same head that hosts theme vowels – is that the nonstandard innovative form that tracks 3pl agreement in the presence of the locative clitic with present tense existential *haber* is always *hayn*, and never something like **hany*. See the following structure of the verb *hayn* after head movement, in which there is no possibility to derive a form in which the locative clitic follows the phi-agreement morpheme.

¹³ There are, however, other auxiliaries in Spanish that do have theme vowels, such as progressive *estar*. The fact that auxiliary *haber* does not have a theme vowel in the unmarked tense while auxiliary *estar* does is evidence that these two auxiliaries should have different underlying structures, with progressive auxiliary *estar* having more internal structure than a standard auxiliary. Further evidence of this claim is that progressive *estar* structures behave much more like biclausal raising/control structures with respect to clitic climbing.

- (v) a. (Lo) estoy viendo (=lo)
 (him) am seeing (=him)
 'I am seeing him'
 b. (Lo) quiero ver (=lo)
 (him) want.1sg see.INF(=him)
 'I want to see him'
 c. (Lo) he visto(*=lo)
 (him) have.1sg seen(*=him)
 'I have seen him'

(82) Structure of *hayn*



In this analysis, nothing in the narrow syntax itself rules out a derivation such as the one in (82) that leads to *hayn*, unless one wants to ascribe the phi-agreement morpheme on T^0 with some kind of featural diacritic saying that it only wants to combine directly with the verbal root (hence the acceptability in all varieties of Spanish of auxiliary *han*). I believe, however, that positing such a stipulative feature is not necessary.

Instead, it can simply be the case that speakers avoid using a form such as *hayn* because it clearly violates the morphophonological well-formedness requirements seen with virtually every other verb in Spanish. Only with *hayn* do we see a third person plural agreement affix combine with something other than a verbal root, theme vowel, or tense morpheme. This is not seen in any other verbal paradigm in any variety of the language. Furthermore, the sound sequence /-ain/ is not seen anywhere else in the tense-and-agreement domain of any other verb. The fact that *hayn* is attested in many varieties of Spanish despite its stigmatization is evidence that we should not pursue an explanation of verbal agreement with existential *haber* that rules it out completely.

Thus, while nothing in the narrow syntax itself rules out *hayn* so long as associate probing via defective circumvention is a possibility in the first place (which it may not be in a variety like what Rodríguez Mondoñedo (2006) describes as SI), *hayn* still stands in violation of any number of cognitive and/or sociolinguistic preferences that Spanish speakers may have about the well-formedness of verbal morphophonology in their language, which contributes to the stigmatization and low prestige of such a verb form. These preferences can also lead speakers to reject the form entirely even though nothing goes wrong with the form in the domain of syntactic agreement itself.

Keeping in mind these generalizations about the possibility of a form such as *hayn*, as well as the fact that the locative clitic is in complementary distribution with the theme vowel because they appear on different iterations of the same head, it is now possible to explain another set of morphological idiosyncrasies of existential *haber* with [Part] agreement.

4.3 *Habemos, not *hemos*

In this portion of the paper, I explain how the considerations given above on the presence of the locative clitic its complementary distribution with the theme vowel, given the analysis of clausal agreement via defective circumvention from sections 2 and 3, are able to derive the fact that first

person plural present tense existential *haber* surfaces as *habemos*, as opposed to *hemos*, which is what appears with other uses of *haber* (e.g., the auxiliary).

The facts presented in this section are applicable to the second person singular present tense form of existential *haber* as well – *habéis* – even though, unlike the 1pl case, the 2pl case does not see a difference in form across other uses of the verb *haber*. That is, both the auxiliary and existential form of *haber* in 2sg present tense are *habéis* in what I anticlimactically consider to be a coincidence. Because of this, the auxiliary and existential forms of 2sg present tense *haber* are not differentiable in the way that they are for 1pl.

However, it is worth mentioning that nonstandard forms of the 2sg present tense auxiliary form of *haber* are historically attested such as *hais* and *heis* (Pietsch 1904; Fábregas 2023) and even survives today in some varieties of Peninsular Spanish (Pérez Pérez 2021), and can also be seen in Judeo-Spanish (Bunis 2021). Indeed, such examples of these nonstandard auxiliaries are very well attested from native European Spanish speakers online, with *hais*-forms being more frequently attested than *heis*-forms. I show some examples here.

- (83) Nunca hais visto el cielo o que?! (Twitter)
 never have.AUX.2pl seen the sky or what
 ‘Have y’all never seen the sky or what?!’
- (84) Señores hais llegado bien o no? (Twitter)
 sirs have.AUX.2pl arrived well or not
 ‘Sirs, have you arrived okay or not?’
- (85) Nunca os hais sentido impotentes por algo? (Twitter)
 never y’all.ACC have.AUX.2pl felt impotent for something
 ‘Have y’all ever felt powerless about something?’

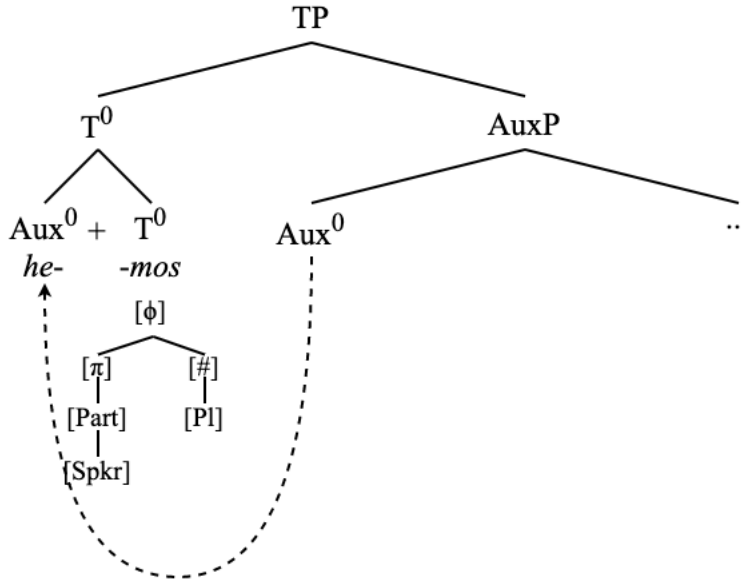
As clearly nonstandard and prescriptively unacceptable as these examples are, I bring them up to say that having a 2sg form of *haber* like *hais*, for those who do accept it, is only possible as an auxiliary. It can never be a form of existential *haber*. There are no such examples online, and they have not ever been described in the sources that mention these forms as historical or dialectal auxiliary forms. Thus, in these nonstandard varieties that allow for *hais* or *heis* as an auxiliary, the 2sg present tense existential *haber* would still only surface as *habéis*, which is consistent with the difference between 1pl auxiliary and existential *haber* and the analysis of existential *haber* presented here.

Here, I explain the following data point concerning [Part] agreement with existential *haber* in unmarked tense clauses.

- (86) {Habe-mos/*he -mos} dos estudiantes en la clase
 {have -1pl/ *have.AUX-1pl} two students in the class
 ‘There are two of us students in the class’

With auxiliary *haber* (which is impossible in existential contexts such as (86)), the first person plural unmarked tense form of the verb combines directly with the verbal root: there is no theme vowel. This combination triggers a change in the root from *ha-* to *he-* which I consider to be of no major importance to the analysis.

(87) [Part] agreement with auxiliary *haber* of unmarked tense, with head movement



With existential *haber*, however, there is a head that intervenes between the verb root and the phi-agreement head. This head – v^0 – hosts the locative clitic under the right conditions, or a theme vowel.

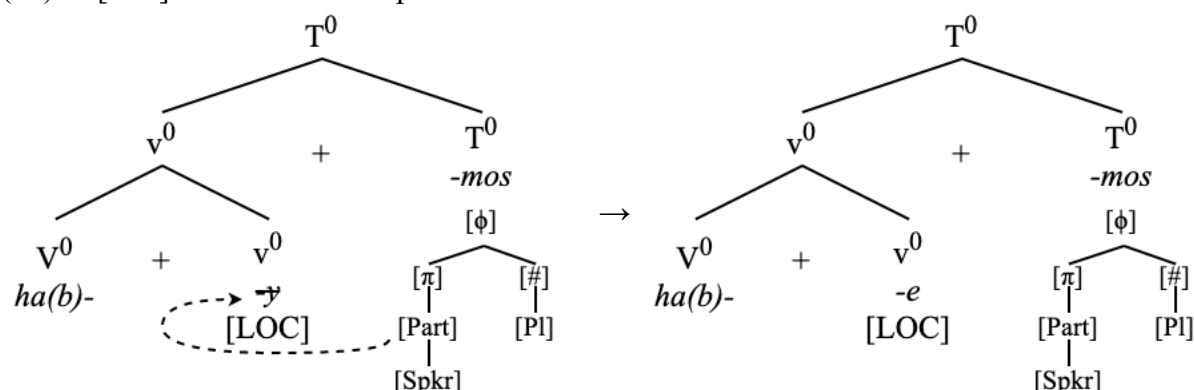
Following the derivation of *ha-y-n* given in the previous subsection, we might expect the 1pl unmarked tense form of existential *haber* to be **ha-y-mos*, but that is not possible, either. Instead of the locative clitic, the theme vowel appears in that position.

- (88) a. $[TP \text{ -mos } [_{VP [LOC] \text{ -y } [_{VP} ha(b)]}]] \rightarrow *haymos$
 b. $[TP \text{ -mos } [_{VP [LOC] \text{ -y } -e } [_{VP} ha(b)]]] \rightarrow habemos$

Why the theme vowel appears instead of the locative clitic here is worthy of discussion. It would not make sense to claim that the existential *haber* v^0 head lacks a locative feature only when T^0 agrees with a first or second person associate, since the v^0 head is externally merged before T^0 (additionally, the lack of the locative v^0 would prevent the existential argument from functioning as the structural subject, given the analysis in section 2).

Instead, the answer lies in the fact that the spellout of the locative clitic is sensitive to the featural makeup of the T^0 head at the time that v^0 incorporates into T^0 via head movement, which we have seen already with the fact that the locative clitic *-y* is only expressed in unmarked tense environments, and there is no locative clitic in non-present and non-indicative clauses.

Given that the expression of the locative clitic is sensitive to the featural makeup of the T^0 head regarding tense, it stands to reason that it is also sensitive to the features that a T^0 head has acquired from phi-agreement. So, just as the locative clitic is not spelled out in the environment of a marked tense feature, it must also be the case that the locative clitic is not spelled out in the environment of a marked person feature (i.e., [Part]), which rules out the forms **haymos* and **hayis*. See (88a) and below.



- (90) a. 1pl *haber*, no v^0 → *hemos* (auxiliary)
b. 1pl *haber*, v^0 → *habemos* (existential)

5 Conclusion

I have shown that the optionality of agreement that appears in existential *haber* clauses with a third person plural associate is explained within a single grammatical system operating over a single set of lexical items. The same system of Agree that derives optional agreement with 3pl associates also leads to obligatory agreement with associates that bear a [Part] feature (the distribution of which is restricted by the definiteness effect), due to the PLC.

The status of the existential argument as a structural subject – and subsequently the associate as a structural object which does receives accusative Case and which can be conditionally (as opposed to obligatorily) agreed with – comes about via the presence of a locative feature probe [_{LOC}] on the *v*⁰ head projected by the existential verb *haber* which moves the existential argument to a position above the associate at the time of A-probing by T⁰.

The data and analysis presented in this paper support a view of Case assignment being driven by Agree with functional heads (Chomsky 2000; 2001) and present complications for any Case-discriminating formulations of Agree as verbal agreement in existential *haber* clauses robustly and systematically track agreement with accusative objects.

A major component of the analysis presented here is the data from nonstandard, colloquial, and stigmatized language varieties. These language varieties inform the analysis in key ways and bring up important considerations that would be overlooked if we only were to focus on standardized language varieties. For instance, the previously-attested claim that the presence of the locative clitic *-y* necessarily blocks the expression of phi-agreement morphology does not hold up when one considers the nonstandard agreement form *hayn*, which shows that it is very much possible to have a phi-agreement morpheme cooccurring with the locative clitic. This fact, in turn, informs the analysis of the [Part]-agreeing forms of *haber* and how they differ from the auxiliary verb.

This paper has also presented a new way of thinking about agreement optionality and intraspeaker variation within a single language that does not necessarily assume the presence of multiple language varieties in a single speaker. In this framework, instead of conflating intraspeaker agreement variation with multidialectalism, a single grammar is able to produce more than one viable configuration as an output in situations where each configuration represents a derivational “fork in the road” for principles of grammatical computation such as economy conditions. Preferences by speakers for certain forms over others, then, are constrained by various cognitive and sociolinguistic preferences that are external to the narrow syntax. The case of agreement variation and optionality with existential *haber* is an excellent case study for this way of modeling syntactic optionality given the high degree of variability in speakers’ agreement preferences across and within speech communities.

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